A DOCTORAL THESIS

Mortmain *and* Metamorphosis

Civil Death, the Remitted Vow, and the Imaginal Humanism of Corpse Bride



On *Corpse Bride* (2005), directed by Tim Burton and Mike Johnson
screenplay by John August, Caroline Thompson, and Pamela Pettler

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Abstract

This dissertation argues that *Corpse Bride* (2005), directed by Tim Burton and Mike Johnson from a screenplay by John August, Caroline Thompson, and Pamela Pettler, is a rigorous philosophical fable about the ontology of obligation and the ethics of release, and that its customary reception—as Gothic romance, auteurist pastiche, or carnivalesque satire of Victorian materialism—has obscured the precision with which it stages the central problems of feminist and humanist thought. Reconstructing the film's lineage from the Ashkenazi tale of the betrothed finger, through the European cycle of the ring placed on the wrong hand (William of Malmesbury, Mérimée), the revenant-bride tradition (Phlegon, Goethe, Bürger, the Child ballads of returned troth, the Wilis of Heine and *Giselle*), and the nineteenth-century aesthetics of the dead beautiful woman (Poe, Bronfen), the study shows that the film's world is organized by a *chiasmus of mortality*. Under the regime of coverture, which Blackstone described as the suspension of a wife's legal existence and the Seneca Falls Declaration of 1848 as rendering her "civilly dead," the living Victorian bride is the true corpse, while the dead bride is the only woman in the film who possesses a will in both the volitional and the testamentary sense.

Close readings of the failed rehearsal, the forest vow, the descent and ascent of the dead, and the church sequence demonstrate that the film literalizes Derrida's critique of Austin: the rehearsed, soliloquized vow that Austin excluded as parasitic upon serious speech is the only felicitous performative the film contains. From this the dissertation derives a category it names the *remissive performative*: the gratuitous extinction of a valid claim by the one who holds it, distinct from annulment by authority, from fulfillment by sacrifice, and from the forgiveness of a trespass. Read through Arendt's pairing of promise and forgiveness, through Mauss and Derrida on the gift, and through Irigaray's speculation on commodities that trade among themselves, the climactic transaction between the two brides inverts the Lévi-Straussian traffic in women

and converts an economy of exchange into an economy of the gift. In the vocabulary of Roman law, it transforms *mortmain*, the dead hand, into *manumissio testamento*, release by the will of the dead.

The dissertation's original contribution, which it terms *imaginal humanism*, draws on the converging senses of *pupa* (girl, doll, puppet, chrysalis), *imago* (adult insect, ancestral death-mask), and *psychē* (breath, soul, butterfly) to argue that the film's passage from the dead hand to the released soul proposes a humanism grounded not in possession, sovereignty, and the binding force of the will, but in the capacity to undergo and to grant transformation. The study distinguishes remission from feminine self-sacrifice by five criteria and a comparative typology of departing women from Alcestis to Stella Dallas; restores, through the Lurianic doctrines of contraction and repair, the Jewish frame that the film's adaptation buried; tests the thesis against the film's limits, including its reconstitution of bourgeois marriage and its racialized sonic coding of vitality; and proposes imaginal humanism as a framework for feminist ethics, the philosophy of law, death studies, and the theory of animation.

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Note on Method, Citation, and Nomenclature



The object of this study is the seventy-seven-minute stop-motion feature released by Warner Bros. in 2005. Because no critical edition of the screenplay exists, and because the argument concerns structures, images, and acts rather than verbal surface, the film is cited by sequence—the prologue, the rehearsal, the forest vow, the ballad, the escape and recapture, the duet, the jurisprudence of the Elder, the ascent of the dead, the church—and its dialogue and songs are described and paraphrased rather than reproduced. Classical, scriptural, and liturgical texts are cited by their standard divisions. Direct quotation is confined to short passages from texts long in the public domain; every other theoretical position is reconstructed in paraphrase and attributed to its originator.

Authorship. The possessive title under which the film was marketed concentrates in one signature a work produced by two directors, three screenwriters, a story artist who carried its source to the production (Joe Ranft), a composer whose score is a structural argument in its own right (Danny Elfman), and the large collective of puppet-makers and animators that stop-motion requires. “The film” therefore designates a collective agent throughout. Where a recurring concern can be traced to a particular collaborator's wider corpus, the attribution is made explicitly and as a hypothesis about convergence, not as a claim about intention.

Method. The study combines four procedures. The first is philosophical criticism in Stanley Cavell's sense, which treats a film as a site where thinking happens rather than as an illustration of doctrine. The second is historical poetics, which reads tale types, genres, and legal regimes as the material the film thinks with. The third is the feminist critique of the political economy of sex, from Wollstonecraft through Rubin, Irigaray, and Pateman. The fourth is media ontology, which asks what it means that a fable of the reanimated dead is itself assembled from still photographs of jointed dolls.

Nomenclature. Five terms are coined or redefined. The **chiasmus of mortality** names the film's crossing of biological and juridical life, in which the living bride is civilly dead and the dead bride is juridically alive. **Mortmain** is used in its legal sense (the inalienable hold of undying institutions and of the dead over property) and in its literal sense (the dead hand that rises from the forest floor). The **remissive performative** names an utterance or act by which the holder of a valid claim extinguishes it gratuitously. The **sororal transaction** names an exchange between women in which a man is the object transferred, inverting the classical traffic in women. **Imaginal humanism** names the dissertation's synthetic thesis: a conception of the human grounded in the capacity to undergo and to grant metamorphosis, elaborated through the entomological and Roman senses of *pupa* and *imago*, the Greek *psychē*, and Henry Corbin's *mundus imaginalis*.

INTRODUCTION

The Hand in the Earth

0.1 *The image*

A young man who has just failed to recite his marriage vows before his bride's parents and their pastor walks into a winter wood and recites them flawlessly to no one. At the culmination of the recitation he slips the ring onto what he takes for a twisted root rising from the snow. The root is a finger, and the hand to which it belongs draws a dead woman in a decayed wedding dress out of the ground to accept him.

Everything this dissertation argues is folded into that image. The hand is the oldest juridical figure of power over persons: Roman *manus*, the authority acquired over a wife who passed "into the hand" of her husband, and *mortmain*, the dead hand by which undying institutions and the deceased held property beyond the reach of the living. The ring is the material form of the bond: a gift that obligates, a token whose transfer perfects a contract, and historically a signet with which deeds were sealed. The earth is what the living order has buried: the dead, the repressed, the chthonic remainder of every settlement of property and desire. In placing the ring on the dead hand, Victor Van Dort contracts with everything his world has interred.

0.2 *The critical field and its omission*

Critical reception has proceeded along three main lines. Auteurist criticism situates the film within the opposition, sustained across Burton's work, between the Gothic outsider and the conforming community, the structure Helena Bassil-Morozow reads as the drama of the monster and the crowd, and within the animation-inflected practice Alison McMahan calls Burton's pataphysical cinema. Genre criticism reads it as a Gothic romance that domesticates the macabre for a family audience. Cultural criticism, generally following Bakhtin, reads the colour-saturated Land of the Dead as a carnival inversion of a grey Victorian order and the ending as comedy's return to equilibrium.

Each reading is correct as far as it goes; each stops short of the film's most consequential material. The vow that binds across death, the law under which the living bride is already dead, the economic transaction that the dead bride converts into a gift, the poisoned cup that would have consummated a love-death, and the act by which the bride ends the film are treated, when noticed at all, as plot machinery or sentiment. This dissertation treats them as philosophy. Its wager is that a family film about a marriage to a corpse can be shown to think, with unusual rigor, about what it is to be bound, what it is to be free, and what a human being owes to those who can no longer claim anything, and to those who still can.

0.3 *The argument*

The argument proceeds through four movements, each corresponding to a structural operation of the film.

The first is a *chiasmus of mortality*. The film's two worlds are coded by palette and sound as death-in-life above and life-in-death below, and criticism has rightly noticed the inversion. What it has not noticed is that the inversion is juridical before it is aesthetic. In the mid-nineteenth-century order the film evokes, a married woman's legal personality was absorbed into her husband's under the doctrine of coverture, and the feminists of that order named the condition civil death. Victoria Everglot, alive and about to be married, approaches a legal death; Emily, dead, is the only woman in the film who exercises a will, first as a volition she pursues and at the last as a testament she executes.

The second is a *theory of the vow*. The film's plot is generated by the most famous example in the modern philosophy of language, the marriage vow with which J. L. Austin opens his account of performative utterances. The vow fails when spoken in its proper setting and succeeds when rehearsed alone, in precisely the soliloquizing, citational mode Austin set aside as parasitic upon serious speech. The film thereby dramatizes Derrida's objection that iterability is the condition of every performative. It then goes further than either philosopher: it asks how a valid vow may be undone, and answers with an act this study calls the *remissive performative*.

The third is a *sororal transaction*. The film's marriages are transactions between families in which daughters are the medium of exchange: title for money, and, in the case of the murdered bride, a dowry for a predator. The climax reverses the structure that Claude Lévi-Strauss made foundational for kinship and that Gayle Rubin and Luce Irigaray subjected to feminist critique. Two women, both brides of the same murderer, transact the release of a man between themselves; the exchange is a gift rather than a trade, and it is sealed by the one rite of the wedding that passes from woman to woman.

The fourth is an *imaginal metamorphosis*. The dead bride ends not in a grave but in a cloud of butterflies rising toward the moon. The image draws on the Greek identification of soul and butterfly (*psychē*), on the entomological vocabulary of *pupa* and *imago*, and, reflexively, on the medium of stop-motion, whose puppets descend etymologically from the Latin *pupa*, doll. Read through this constellation, the ending converts the dead hand into a released soul and mortality into what Hannah Arendt called natality: the capacity to begin.

0.4 *The contribution*

The synthetic thesis that emerges, *imaginal humanism*, has three components. First, it proposes the remissive performative as a third faculty of action alongside the two Arendt identified as redeeming action from its predicaments: the promise, which binds the future, and forgiveness, which releases the past. Remission releases a right, a present claim upon another's future, and is the act by which a sovereign subject uses its sovereignty to undo its own hold. Second, it supplies criteria that distinguish remission from the feminine self-sacrifice that feminist criticism has rightly indicted in the traditions the film inherits, from Alcestis to Madama Butterfly. Third, it reads the ending as a humanism of transformation rather than of possession, correcting Pico della Mirandola's metamorphic conception of human dignity by insisting that the dignity of transformation belongs to the one who authors it, not to the one on whom it is imposed.

A further, reparative contribution concerns the film's source. The tale that reached the production was Jewish; the adaptation dissolved its Ashkenazi and juridical setting into an ethnically unmarked European Gothic. The final chapter argues that the film's resolution is nonetheless structurally homologous with the Lurianic doctrines of divine contraction, the breaking of the vessels, and repair, and treats the restoration of that frame as an act of critical restitution: hauntological justice to the buried source.

0.5 *Why a family film*

To read a children's entertainment as philosophy requires no apology after Cavell, who demonstrated that popular cinema could bear the full weight of moral perfectionism and of the problem of other minds. The family film is in any case a privileged object for the questions at stake here, since it is the genre in which a culture instructs its young about the two institutions this film fuses, marriage and death. Geoffrey Gorer argued in 1955 that death had replaced sex as the unspeakable subject of modern Anglophone culture; *Corpse Bride* addresses both taboos at once, in a register designed for children, and resolves them neither by moral warning nor by sentimental reassurance but by an ethical act.

That it does so through stop-motion is not incidental. In that medium inert bodies are given motion one photograph at a time, so that every movement on screen is a resurrection performed by a human hand. The medium is itself a theory of animation in the oldest sense of the word: the giving of *anima*, breath and soul, to what has none.

0.6 *Plan of the work*

Part One reconstructs genealogies. Chapter 1 assembles the folkloric, ballad, and Romantic sources and identifies the film's decisive alteration of its tale type: the transfer of the power of annulment from external authority to the claimant herself. Chapter 2 reads the film as the convergence of five authorial corpora. Chapter 3 lays out the philosophical thanatology, from the *Phaedo* and Montaigne to Heidegger, Levinas, and Arendt, together with the humanisms on which the readings draw.

Part Two offers close readings organized by problem. Chapter 4 develops the chiasmus of mortality through the law of coverture and the political economy of the arranged match. Chapter 5 reads the vow through the theory of the performative and the history of marriage formation. Chapter 6 treats the Land of the Dead as katabatic counter-world and as carnival, with attention to its sonic politics. Chapter 7 analyses the doubling of the brides and the sororal transaction. Chapter 8 reads the Wine of Ages as pharmakon and reconstructs the film's theory of justice. Chapter 9 develops the constellation of psyche, pupa, and imago and the ontology of the medium.

Part Three states imaginal humanism as a systematic thesis, defends it against five objections, and draws out its implications for feminist ethics, the philosophy of law, death studies, and the theory of animation.



PART ONE

Genealogies

1 · The Betrothed Finger
2 · A Polyphonic Authorship
3 · Thanatology and the Human

CHAPTER ONE

1 The Betrothed Finger: Folkloric, Ballad, and Romantic Sources

The film's tale type is ancient and widely distributed, and its single most consequential innovation is to remove the external authority that, in every prior version, decides whether a vow made to the dead binds the living. This chapter assembles the sources, sets them in a comparative matrix, and isolates that innovation.

1.1 *The Ashkenazi kernel*

The narrative kernel reached the production through the story artist Joe Ranft, who brought to Burton a Jewish tale in which a young man, jesting, places a ring on what appears to be a finger protruding from the earth and recites the betrothal formula, whereupon a dead woman rises to claim him as her husband. Howard Schwartz anthologized the tale as “The Finger” in *Lilith's Cave: Jewish Tales of the Supernatural* (1988), a collection whose corpus is rich in tales from the kabbalistic milieu of sixteenth-century Safed. In its canonical shape the case is brought before rabbinic authority, which rules that the dead have no claim upon the living, and the bride returns to her grave.

The tale is not merely uncanny; it is a juridical thought experiment. Jewish betrothal (*kiddushin*) is effected by a man's transfer to a woman of an object of minimal value, classically a ring, before two qualified witnesses, together with a declaration that she is consecrated to him by this ring according to the law of Moses and Israel. The procedure is formal in a strong sense: properly performed, it produces its effect irrespective of the inner states that accompany it. The tale therefore asks whether a performative so formal can bind when uttered in jest, before companions who happen to satisfy the requirement of witnesses, to a counterparty who is not alive. Its answer protects the community of the living by locating the power of annulment in the court. The release is adjudicated, not given.

The tale also belongs to a wider Jewish repertoire of demonic betrothal, in which a ring slipped in play onto a branch or protrusion binds a youth to a she-demon. That repertoire is shadowed by the figure of Lilith and by the anxiety that a speech act, once performed, can summon a partner from outside the human community. The corpse bride is its most humanized member: not a demon but a woman who died before her wedding, whose claim, however impossible, is the claim of an injured party.

The film's paratexts described its source generically as a Russian folktale. The designation is not false, since cognate versions circulated in Eastern European oral tradition, but it performs a silent conversion. A tale with a determinate religious, juridical, and communal setting becomes an ethnically unmarked European fable, and the court that adjudicated it disappears. Popular accounts of the tale's origin, whose textual warrant is uncertain, say that the bride was murdered by antisemitic attackers on her way to her wedding. Whatever the status of that detail, its circulation ties the dead bride to a real history: the pogroms of the Russian Empire, in which mobs attacked and killed Jews, often with the tolerance of the authorities. The film carries none of that history. Chapter 10 returns to this erasure as the film's own unquiet grave.

1.2 *The ring on the wrong hand*

A second lineage, European and Christian, binds a groom not to a dead woman but to a statue. William of Malmesbury's *Gesta Regum Anglorum* (c. 1125) tells of a young Roman bridegroom who, before a game of ball, sets his wedding ring for safekeeping on the finger of a bronze Venus. The finger closes over the ring, and on his wedding night the goddess lies between him and his bride, claiming him as betrothed, until a priest versed in necromancy compels the ring's return. Prosper Mérimée's "La Vénus d'Ille" (1837) transposes the tale to Roussillon: the groom places his ring on an excavated bronze Venus, cannot recover it, and is found crushed to death in the bridal bed. Joseph von Eichendorff's "Das Marmorbild" (1819) supplies the Romantic variant of a marble Venus who comes alive to seduce a young man from his Christian beloved.

Three features of this cycle pass into the film. First, the ring's efficacy is mechanical: it binds by contact and form, without regard to intention, and this is precisely what makes it horrifying. Second, the claimant figures an erotic past that the Christian marriage has repressed, pagan desire buried under the new order and, in Mérimée, literally excavated from the ground. Third, the resolution requires either an exorcist or a death. Tzvetan Todorov made Mérimée's tale an exemplary case of the fantastic, the genre of hesitation between natural and supernatural explanation, and observed more generally that the fantastic often

begins when a figurative expression is taken literally. Chapter 5 shows that this principle of literalization governs the entire plot of *Corpse Bride*.

1.3 *The revenant bride*

The third lineage is that of the dead maiden who returns to claim the marriage denied her in life. Its earliest substantial witness is the *Book of Marvels* of Phlegon of Tralles (second century CE), which preserves the case of Philinnion of Amphipolis, some months dead, who visits the young guest Machates by night in her parents' house. The lovers exchange tokens, among them rings and a gilded cup. When her parents surprise her she reproaches them for interrupting what the powers below had permitted, and dies a second time; her body is removed and burned. Ring and cup, the two objects on which the film's vow and climax turn, are already the currency of the revenant marriage.

Goethe's ballad “Die Braut von Korinth” (1797) recasts Phlegon's tale as a conflict between pagan eros and Christian asceticism. A young Athenian arrives in Corinth to claim the bride promised him in pagan days; her family has converted, and a mother's vow has consigned the daughter to heaven and therefore to the grave. The dead girl comes to him by night, they exchange tokens and drink dark wine, and when her mother discovers them the bride declares that she has returned to seek the bridegroom taken from her, that she will draw his life, and that her body must be burned so that she may go back to the old gods. Goethe's revenant is the first fully articulated figure of the dead bride as protest: her vampirism is the return of the eros that a moral order sacrificed. Emily inherits the protest without the predation.

The revenant marriage in this lineage is consummated. Philinnion comes to the young man's bed by night, and Goethe's bride spends the night with her betrothed as his lover before her mother discovers them. *Corpse Bride* withholds the consummation entirely: Emily returns to collect a vow, not a wedding night. The film thereby converts erotic revenance into juridical revenance, and the argument of Chapters 5 and 10 depends on that conversion, since what the dead bride holds, and can therefore remit, is a claim rather than a body.

1.4 *The dead bridegroom*

The inverse figure dominates the Romantic ballad. In Gottfried August Bürger's "Lenore" (1774), the most influential ballad of its century, a girl whose betrothed has not returned from war despairs and blasphemes. At midnight a rider arrives, carries her at terrible speed to a bridal bed that proves to be a grave, and is revealed as a skeleton. The poem's refrain, that the dead ride fast, passed through Walter Scott's translation into the English Gothic. "Lenore" disciplines female grief: the woman's excessive desire for the absent man is punished by literal union with death.

Corpse Bride inverts the genders and refuses the discipline. The dead claimant is a woman, the living party is a man, and the film nowhere punishes the dead bride's desire. It treats that desire as legitimate, her claim as valid, and her suffering as the consequence not of her own excess but of a man's predation.

1.5 *The economy of troth*

The British ballad tradition supplies the juridical-erotic token the film's ending requires. In "Sweet William's Ghost" (Child 77), the dead lover comes to his betrothed's window to ask for the return of the faith and troth he plighted her, without which he cannot rest; when she gives it back, he departs. In "The Unquiet Grave" (Child 78), the direction of grief reverses: a mourner who has wept at a grave for a twelvemonth and a day is told by the dead that the weeping disturbs their rest, and is urged to be content. The first ballad establishes that a pledge outlives death and that its restitution is the condition of the dead's peace. The second establishes that the bond of grief can become a bondage from which the dead themselves ask release.

The Book of Common Prayer of 1662, whose marriage service shaped the vows of the film's Anglophone world, binds the couple with the same word: the man plights and the woman gives her troth, and each promises fidelity "till death us do part." The troth is thus a liturgical as well as a ballad object, and the plot of *Corpse Bride* can be described in its terms. A troth is plighted by accident; the dead claimant cannot rest until it is resolved; and the resolution, as in Child 77, is its return. The film's decisive change is that the troth is returned by the dead to the living, by the woman to the man, and freely.

1.6 *The Wilis*

The closest structural analogue is the nineteenth century's most celebrated dead bride. Heinrich Heine's "Elementargeister" (1837) relates a Slavic legend of the Wilis, maidens who died before their wedding days and rise at night to dance any young man they meet to death. Théophile Gautier and Jules-Henri Vernoy de Saint-Georges built from it the libretto of *Giselle* (1841), with music by Adolphe Adam. A peasant girl is courted by a nobleman in disguise who is already betrothed to a noblewoman, Bathilde; exposed, he leaves Giselle to die of the betrayal, and she joins the Wilis. When he comes to her grave the Wilis condemn him, but Giselle protects him until dawn breaks their power, and returns to her grave having refused vengeance.

The homology with *Corpse Bride* is exact in its elements and instructive in its differences. Both feature a dead bride, a class-stratified betrothal to a living noblewoman, a man condemned by the dead, and the dead woman's renunciation of vengeance in favor of his life. But Giselle's Albrecht is the author of her death, so her mercy is forgiveness of the guilty; Victor is innocent of Emily's death, and the guilty man is a third party who is punished. Giselle's renunciation also leaves the living order intact, since the noble engagement simply resumes. Emily's transfers the man to the living bride as a gift and thereby alters the meaning of the marriage that follows. *Corpse Bride* is a *Giselle* in which Albrecht is innocent, the murderer is unmasked, and the dead woman's mercy becomes an act of authorship.

1.7 *The matrix and the decisive alteration*

Read together, the sources compose a matrix of variables: the bond, the claimant, the resolution, and the authority that releases.

Source	Bond	Claimant	Resolution	Who releases
Ashkenazi tale, "The Finger" (Schwartz 1988)	Betrothal formula and ring, spoken in jest	Dead bride	The dead are ruled to have no claim on the living	Rabbinic court
William of Malmesbury, *Gesta Regum Anglorum* (c. 1125)	Wedding ring set on a statue's finger	Venus	Ring recovered by necromantic intercession	Priest-magician
Mérimée, "La Vénus d'Ille" (1837)	Wedding ring set on a bronze Venus	Animated statue	Groom crushed on the wedding night	No one: the claim is executed
Phlegon, Philinnion (2nd c. CE)	Rings and cup exchanged	Dead maiden	Discovery, second death, body burned	Parents and civic ritual
Goethe, "Die Braut von Korinth" (1797)	Pagan betrothal; tokens exchanged	Dead bride	Bride demands the pyre; groom doomed	The bride, for herself only

Source	Bond	Claimant	Resolution	Who releases
Bürger, "Lenore" (1774)	Betrothal; despairing blasphemy	Dead bridegroom	Bride carried to the grave	No one: desire is punished
"Sweet William's Ghost" (Child 77)	Plighted troth	Dead lover	Troth returned	The living woman
"The Unquiet Grave" (Child 78)	Bond of mourning	Living mourner	The dead ask for an end to grief	The dead, by request
Giselle (1841)	Deceived betrothal	The Wilis	Giselle shields the man until dawn	Dawn, and the dead woman's mercy
Corpse Bride (2005)	Rehearsed vow, ring, and the bride's assent	Dead bride	Ring returned; living couple joined	The claimant herself

The matrix discloses the film's most consequential decision. In every source but two, the power to release the living from a bond with the dead lies outside the claimant: in a rabbinic court, a necromancer-priest, a civic ritual, a punishing order, the dawn, or the claim's fatal execution. Goethe's bride claims the power to end her own revenance but not to release her lover, and the ballad of returned troth places release in a person, but there it is the living who release the dead.

Corpse Bride removes external adjudication entirely. Its Elder can interpret the vow but not dissolve it, and his only remedy is the groom's death. Its pastor, guardian of the living form, is complicit in the confinement of the living bride. The power to annul passes to the claimant herself, who exercises it not by renouncing a claim she lacks but by remitting one she holds. That transfer, from adjudication to remission, is the hinge on which the whole argument of this dissertation turns.

CHAPTER TWO

A Polyphonic Authorship: Burton, Johnson, August, Thompson, Pettler

The film's philosophy is the convergence of five authorial corpora, each of which had already been working, independently, toward the same problem: how the dead, and the living who cling to them, are to be released from attachments that have become possession. This chapter reconstructs that convergence and argues that the film's ethic of remission is overdetermined by its collective authorship.

2.1 *Against the single signature*

The possessive title under which the film was released belongs to the economy of the brand, not to the economy of production. Stop-motion is the most collective of cinematic arts: each second of screen time requires the coordinated labor of puppet fabricators, costume makers, set builders, riggers, camera operators, and animators who adjust a figure by fractions of a millimetre between exposures. To read the film through one name is to repeat, at the level of criticism, the gesture the film itself critiques: the attribution of a shared work to the hand that holds the title.

The method adopted here borrows Mikhail Bakhtin's account of polyphony, the coexistence in one work of plural consciousnesses that are not merged into a single authorial voice. The film is read as a polyphonic text in which recurrent concerns of each collaborator can be identified and shown to converge. These attributions are hypotheses about convergence, not claims about intention.

2.2 *Burton: the Gothic and the crowd*

Burton's work had treated death as a domestic intimacy from the beginning. *Vincent* (1982), a stop-motion short narrated by Vincent Price, follows a suburban boy who conducts his inner life in the idiom of Poe and of Price's screen persona. *Frankenweenie* (1984) resurrects a child's dead dog, Sparky, by the methods of Mary Shelley's Victor; Scraps, the skeletal dog who rejoins Victor Van Dort in the Land of the Dead, is Sparky's descendant, and his presence there makes a child's first experience of loss the gateway to the film's underworld. *Sleepy Hollow* (1999) turns on a murderous plot to capture an inheritance, an early instance of the alliance between property and killing that Lord Barkis embodies.

Beetlejuice (1988) is the decisive precedent, because it is the ethical inverse of *Corpse Bride*. Its afterlife is a bureaucracy of waiting rooms and caseworkers, and its dead trickster attempts to coerce a living teenage girl, a minor, into marriage as his passport out of death and into dominion over the living. The marriage ceremony there is a forced performative, framed as predation and interrupted at the last moment. Seventeen years later, the same filmmaker imagines a dead woman who could compel a living man to complete a marriage and instead dissolves it, releasing both him and herself. Over the interval, Burton's afterlife changed from Kafkaesque to Rabelaisian, and the dead claimant changed from predator to the bearer of a just claim she chooses not to enforce.

The visual genealogy is equally pointed. The oblique roofs and compressed verticals of the living town descend from German Expressionism, above all *Das Cabinet des Dr. Caligari* (1920), whose architecture externalizes a disordered authority. James Whale's *Bride of Frankenstein* (1935) ends with the Monster releasing the living couple and declaring, of himself and his bride, “We belong dead”: a male precedent for remission, but enacted in despair and by destruction. Hammer horror lends the film two of its voices, since Christopher Lee and Michael Gough, both veterans of Hammer's *Dracula* (1958), voice the pastor of the living and the elder of the dead, so that the two jurisdictions of the film are presided over by icons of the same Gothic institution. Ray Harryhausen, whose skeletal warriors defined stop-motion's relation to the dead, is honored by name on the piano of the Land of the Dead: the medium inscribes its own ancestry of reanimation.

Helena Bassil-Morozow reads Burton's work as the confrontation of the monster with the crowd. *Corpse Bride* revises the formula decisively. The outsider is no longer alone: the dead bride belongs to a second crowd, a community of the dead with its own music, institutions, and law. The Burtonian outsider acquires a polity, and with it the possibility of an ethics that is not merely individual protest.

2.3 *Mike Johnson and the hand of the animator*

Mike Johnson's co-direction anchors the film in the stop-motion tradition of the 1990s features, and the craft decisions of the production bear directly on its meaning. The principal puppets were fitted with internal mechanisms in their heads, adjusted between frames, that allow continuous micro-variation of expression rather than the substitution of sculpted replacement faces. The consequence is that the film's ethical climax, a moment of recognition between two women, can be carried by minute changes of the eyes and mouth. The production was also, reportedly, among the first of its kind photographed frame by frame on digital still cameras.

Stop-motion makes visible a structure that live-action conceals: every motion on screen is the trace of a hand that moved an inert body and then withdrew so that the camera could record it. The animator's hand, which gives motion and then disappears from the frame, is the exact formal counterpart of the hand that rises from the earth in the forest. One hand claims; the other gives and withdraws. Chapter 9 develops the consequence: the medium itself enacts the ethic of remission it depicts.

2.4 *Caroline Thompson: the stitched woman and the dead mother's garden*

Caroline Thompson's screenplays supply three structures the film recombines. *Edward Scissorhands* (1990), from a story by Burton and Thompson, concerns an unfinished man whose inventor died before completing him. The pastel suburb receives his gifts, turns on him, and exiles him; the film ends with Edward ageless in his castle, carving the ice whose shavings fall as snow on the town below. The gift is given from exile to a community that cannot receive the giver: a prototype of a gift whose purity depends on the giver's absence.

The Nightmare Before Christmas (1993), directed by Henry Selick from Thompson's screenplay, gives the Burtonian world its first fully realized heroine. Sally is a stitched woman whose maker confines her; she drugs him to escape, her limbs detach and are sewn back, and her clear-sighted warnings go unheeded. Emily inherits Sally's detachable body and her moral lucidity. Where Sally escapes a maker, Emily escapes a vow, and in both cases the woman whose body is visibly assembled is the one who sees most truly.

The Secret Garden (1993), from Frances Hodgson Burnett's novel, turns on a locked garden in which a mother died and around whose death an entire household has frozen in grief. Reopening the garden restores the living. The space of the dead woman, once opened rather than sealed, becomes the generative

center of the household. That is precisely the function of the Land of the Dead in *Corpse Bride*.

2.5 *John August: death as metamorphosis*

John August's *Big Fish* (2003), from Daniel Wallace's novel, ends with a son narrating his dying father's death as a metamorphosis. The father is carried to the river where the figures of his tall tales wait for him, and he becomes a fish; at the funeral those figures prove to exist. Death becomes transformation into an animal, attended by a community, and narration becomes the gift that releases the dying. The structure prefigures Emily's lepidopteran exit, attended by the community of the dead.

August's *Charlie and the Chocolate Factory* (2005) concerns an inheritance decided by moral selection and a child who will not accept a fortune at the price of leaving his family. Across his corpus, which later includes the screenplay of the feature-length *Frankenweenie* (2012), the family figures as a counter-economy to capital, and death as a passage the living can accompany without arresting.

2.6 *Pamela Pettler: the release of the possessed*

Pamela Pettler's subsequent screenplays make the convergence explicit. *Monster House* (2006), written with Dan Harmon and Rob Schrab, concerns a house possessed by the spirit of a woman once exhibited and mocked as a circus giantess, whose husband built the house around her body after her accidental death in its foundations. The house is a monstrous-feminine body that devours trespassers; its destruction releases the woman's spirit and frees her husband from decades of grief that had become entombment. 9 (2009) ends with the souls of stitched creatures rising as lights. In both, possessive attachment entombs, and release is the condition of peace for the dead and the living alike.

2.7 *Ranft, Elfman, and the paratext of mourning*

Joe Ranft, the story artist who brought the source to the production, died in August 2005, shortly before the film's release, and the film is dedicated to his memory. A work about the dead releasing the living is thus framed by an act of mourning that releases a dead collaborator without reclaiming him: the paratext performs what the narrative depicts.

Danny Elfman's score is a structural argument in its own right. It divides the film into a constrained, minor-key idiom for the living and a brass-and-percussion swing for the dead, and it assigns the piano a narrative function that culminates in

the duet discussed in Chapter 9. Elfman himself voices Bonejangles, the skeletal bandleader whose ballad narrates the dead bride's history.

2.8 *Convergence*

The five corpora converge on one structure. An attachment hardens into possession: a maker's hold on his creature, a husband's grief entombing his wife, a household frozen around a dead mother, a dead man's need to marry the living. Release then restores both parties: the creature walks free, the spirit rises, the garden opens, the father becomes a fish in a river full of friends. *Corpse Bride* is the point at which these independent inquiries meet, and the ethic of remission it articulates is what these artists had separately been learning to say.

CHAPTER THREE

Thanatology and the Human: A Philosophical Genealogy

3

The film inherits two opposed philosophical traditions about death. One treats death as the horizon that individuates, to be faced alone and resolutely; the other treats it as a passage into community, transformation, and festivity. The film resolves their opposition in a humanism of release, whose elements this chapter assembles.

3.1 *Learning to die*

In the *Phaedo*, Socrates maintains that those who practice philosophy rightly practice nothing other than dying and being dead (64a), and that death is the release of the soul from the body's confinement (67d). He drinks the hemlock without protest, and his last words concern a debt: a cock owed to Asclepius. Philosophy's paradigmatic death ends with an obligation discharged, and *Corpse Bride* ends the same way, with a dead woman discharging an obligation, though by releasing it rather than paying it.

Montaigne's essay "That to philosophize is to learn to die" (*Essais* I.20, 1580) secularizes the Platonic exercise. The aim is to strip death of its strangeness by frequenting it, so that its approach no longer paralyzes life. Montaigne recalls, after Herodotus (II.78), the Egyptian custom of carrying a wooden image of a corpse among the guests at a banquet, with the exhortation to drink and be merry, since all present will soon be as it is. The tavern of the dead in *Corpse Bride*, where skeletons drink and dance, is that banquet extended into a society: the memento mori converted from ascetic contempt for the world into an invitation to festivity.

3.2 *Epicurus and Lucretius*

Epicurus' *Letter to Menoeceus* argues that death is nothing to us, since where death is we are not. Lucretius (*De rerum natura* III) adds the symmetry argument, that posthumous nonexistence should trouble us no more than prenatal nonexistence, and describes death as the dissolution of a compound into its elements. He mocks the mourner who imagines himself present at his own funeral, grieving over a body he no longer inhabits.

The film's final image is suspended between the Lucretian and the Platonic. A swarm of butterflies disperses, as a compound dissolves into its elements; the swarm rises toward the moon, as a soul ascends. The film declines to decide between these metaphysics, and the refusal is a humanist one. The meaning of Emily's act is secured by what it does in this world, among these persons, whatever becomes of her afterwards.

3.3 *Danse macabre, calavera, carnival*

The late-medieval Dance of Death, painted at Lübeck and engraved by Hans Holbein the Younger (Lyon, 1538), shows Death leading pope, emperor, merchant, and plowman alike. Its politics are leveling: rank is a costume that the skeleton beneath it exposes. José Guadalupe Posada's calaveras of the early twentieth century renewed the satire, dressing skeletons in the finery of social pretension. His *Calavera Garbancera*, later named *La Catrina* by Diego Rivera, mocked those who disowned their Indigenous origins to ape European fashion. The Everglots and the Van Dorts are living calaveras: the skeleton of rank, its flesh already gone, still wearing the costume of rank. The Mexican Día de Muertos, meanwhile, institutionalizes what the film's climax enacts, an annual return of the dead to visit their kin.

Bakhtin's *Rabelais and His World* gives these traditions their theory. Carnival suspends hierarchy, celebrates the grotesque body, open, protruding, dismembered, and in becoming, and practices a laughter that is regenerative rather than satirical. Carnival death is pregnant death, always bound to birth and renewal. The film's dead embody the grotesque body in every particular, from detachable limbs to skulls inhabited by talking worms, and its ending realizes the regenerative principle in a literal metamorphosis.

3.4 *Zhuangzi: the transformation of things*

The second chapter of the *Zhuangzi*, on the equalizing of things, ends with the most famous butterfly in philosophy. Zhuang Zhou dreamed that he was a butterfly, fluttering happily, and on waking did not know whether he was Zhou who had dreamed of being a butterfly or a butterfly dreaming that it was Zhou. There must be some distinction, the text concludes, and this is called the transformation of things (*wuhua*). In the eighteenth chapter, Zhuangzi's friend Huizi finds him, newly widowed, drumming on a basin and singing. Zhuangzi explains that he grieved at first, then understood that his wife had arisen from formlessness and returned to it as the seasons follow one another; to wail would be to fail to understand fate.

The film's festive dead, who sing at what should be funerals, are closer to Zhuangzi than to Christian eschatology, and its final butterfly is an image of *wuhua*, the passage of one form into another as the ordinary course of things. The equalizing of things also names the social order of the Land of the Dead, in which the distinctions of rank that organize the living have lost their hold.

3.5 *Idealism, its critics, and the family of the dead*

Hegel's *Phenomenology of Spirit* (1807) assigns the burial of the dead to the family: by interment the family rescues the dead from mere nature and makes death an ethical act. Woman is the guardian of this divine, nether law of kinship and the underworld, man of the human law of the state, and womankind is named the everlasting irony of the community. *Corpse Bride* literalizes this ethical geography, with a nether realm of kin and the dead beneath an upper realm of commerce, rank, and public law. It reverses the valuation: the nether law becomes the source of justice for the upper world. Luce Irigaray, in *Speculum of the Other Woman*, reads Hegel's assignment as the confinement of woman to blood and the underground, and Judith Butler's *Antigone's Claim* reads Antigone as exposing the contingency of the kinship norms Hegel naturalized.

Antigone is in fact the first corpse bride of Western philosophy. Creon condemns Sophocles' heroine to be walled up alive for burying her brother, and she addresses her rock-cut tomb as her bridal chamber, going, in her own words, to marry the river of the dead. She hangs herself in the tomb; Haemon, Creon's son and her betrothed, kills himself beside her body; and Creon's wife, Eurydice, kills herself on hearing the news. The bride of death takes her bridegroom with her, and her devotion to a dead brother destroys the living house of Creon. Emily inverts each term: she rises from her tomb rather than entering it, her final

devotion to the living frees the dead, and she refuses the outcome Antigone's marriage to death produced, a bridegroom who follows his bride into the grave.

The film also stages the quarrel between Kant and Hegel over marriage. Kant's *Metaphysics of Morals* (1797) defines marriage as a contract for the lifelong reciprocal possession of the spouses' sexual attributes and classifies the conjugal bond under a right to a person akin to a right to a thing. On this account a spouse who absconds may be recovered as one recovers a thing. Hegel's *Philosophy of Right* (1821) replies that to subsume marriage under contract is shameful, and defines it as ethical love that transcends contractual particularity. The arranged match of the living families is Kantian possession in its crudest commercial form. Emily's recapture of the fleeing Victor, whom she pursues and drags back below, is Kant's right of recovery enacted to the letter. Her final act exceeds both the Kantian contract and the Hegelian ethical substance.

Ludwig Feuerbach's *Essence of Christianity* (1841) reads the afterlife as the projection of the human essence that earthly life withholds, and Marx's 1844 introduction to the critique of Hegel calls religion the sigh of the oppressed creature and "the heart of a heartless world." The Land of the Dead is a Feuerbachian projection of everything the living lack: color, music, conviviality, and the freedom to feel. The film then reverses the alienation by returning the projected heart to the heartless world, in the ascent of the dead.

Arthur Schopenhauer grounds morality in compassion, the recognition in another's suffering of one's own being, summed up in the Vedic formula *tat tvam asi*, "that thou art," and he treats music as an immediate copy of the will. Nietzsche's *Birth of Tragedy* (1872) opposes the Apollonian principle of form and individuation to the Dionysian principle of music, intoxication, and the dissolution of individuality. The living town is an Apollonian order cut off from its Dionysian ground; the Land of the Dead is a Dionysian festival; and the ending dissolves an individual into a multitude. Søren Kierkegaard's *Works of Love* (1847) argues that recollecting one who is dead is the freest and most faithful work of love, because the dead can make no return. *Corpse Bride* inverts the argument: the dead perform the work of love for the living, who cannot repay them.

3.6 *Twentieth-century thanatologies*

Heidegger's *Being and Time* (1927, §§46–53) defines authentic existence as being-toward-death, the anticipation of one's ownmost, non-relational possibility. It opposes this to the averageness of the "they" (*das Man*), whose idle talk tranquilizes the thought of death. The Land of the Living is the world of the "they," and its town crier is idle talk incarnate. Emmanuel Levinas reverses Heidegger's priority. In *Totality and Infinity* (1961) and the lectures on God, death, and time, the death of the other precedes my own in ethical significance, and the face of the other forbids murder before any argument is made. Emily's decisive act, as Chapter 7 shows, is commanded by a face. Hannah Arendt's *The Human Condition* (1958) answers her teacher by making natality, not mortality, the central category of political thought: to act is to begin. She identifies promising and forgiving as the faculties that redeem action from unpredictability and irreversibility, and holds that the story of a life, which discloses who someone was, can be told only after it ends.

Freud supplies four instruments. "The Theme of the Three Caskets" (1913) argues that the man's choice among three women, in *King Lear*, *The Merchant of Venice*, the judgment of Paris, and *Cinderella*, conceals the necessity of death: the third, silent woman is Death, transformed by wish into the most beautiful. "Mourning and Melancholia" (1917) defines mourning as the work of withdrawing attachment from a lost object and melancholia as the incorporation of that object into the self. "The Uncanny" (1919) and *Beyond the Pleasure Principle* (1920) add the return of the familiar repressed, the compulsion to repeat, and the death drive. Lacan's seminar on the ethics of psychoanalysis (1959–60) locates Antigone between two deaths, the symbolic and the real, and Slavoj Žižek reads the living dead of popular culture as returning to collect an unpaid symbolic debt. Emily occupies exactly this zone: dead in body, alive in an unfinished symbolic bond.

Georges Bataille's *Eroticism* (1957) describes human beings as discontinuous creatures who long for a continuity that eroticism and death alike approach, and *The Accursed Share* (1949) opposes a general economy of expenditure to the restricted economy of utility. Philippe Ariès's histories of death trace a passage from the tame death of the Middle Ages through the Romantic and Victorian cult of the beloved dead, which he calls "thy death," to the forbidden death of the twentieth century. Geoffrey Gorer's "The Pornography of Death" (1955) and Ernest Becker's *The Denial of Death* (1973) describe a culture that hides death and compensates with projects of symbolic immortality such as lineage and status.

Anthropology supplies the ritual grammar. Robert Hertz's study of double obsequies (1907) identifies an intermediary period, during which the corpse decomposes and the soul wanders between worlds, closed by a final ceremony

that installs the dead among the ancestors and frees the mourners. Arnold van Gennep's *Rites of Passage* (1909) analyzes marriage and funeral alike as sequences of separation, liminality, and incorporation, and Victor Turner (1969) names the egalitarian bond of the liminal condition *communitas*, opposed to structure. E. E. Evans-Pritchard's account of Nuer ghost marriage (1951), in which a woman is married in the name of a dead man and bears children who count as his, shows that marriage across the boundary of death is not merely a fantasy but an institution.

3.7 *Humanisms and their discontents*

Pico della Mirandola's *Oration on the Dignity of Man* (1486) grounds human dignity in indeterminacy: the human has no fixed seat in the order of being and may become what it chooses, a chameleon among creatures. Erasmus's *Praise of Folly* (1511) gives humanism a carnival voice, and Montaigne joins the art of living to the art of dying. Liberal humanism then recasts the subject as owner. John Locke's *Second Treatise* (1689) gives each man property in his own person; C. B. Macpherson (1962) named the resulting conception possessive individualism, in which the individual is proprietor of his capacities and owes nothing to society for them. Kant grounds dignity in rational autonomy while classifying the wife under a right akin to a right over things, and John Stuart Mill extends liberty to women in *The Subjection of Women* (1869). Marx's 1844 manuscripts propose that the relation of man to woman is the index of how far humanity has become human.

Sartre's *Existentialism Is a Humanism* (1946) makes existence prior to essence, and his *No Exit* (1944) imagines an afterlife in which hell is other people; the Land of the Dead inverts the formula, since there other people are the consolation. Simone de Beauvoir's *The Second Sex* (1949) analyzes woman as the Other, confined to immanence, and marriage as the destiny society holds out to her; *The Ethics of Ambiguity* (1947) holds that to will oneself free is to will others free; *All Men Are Mortal* (1946) argues that immortality would drain projects of their meaning. Martha Nussbaum's capabilities approach (2000) specifies the threshold capacities, from bodily integrity and emotion to play and affiliation, below which a life falls short of dignity.

Feminist and posthumanist critique has indicted the humanist subject as a masculine, propertied, and colonial particular that passes itself off as universal. Irigaray exposes the sexual indifference of the universal; Rosi Braidotti's *Metamorphoses* (2002) and *The Posthuman* (2013) propose a nomadic subject of becoming; Donna Haraway's "Cyborg Manifesto" (1985) dissolves the boundaries that secured the human. The question this dissertation puts to *Corpse Bride* is whether a humanism can be reconstructed that survives these critiques. Its

answer is a humanism whose paradigmatic act is release rather than possession, whose subject is relational and transformable, and whose dignity is measured by what it can give up without ceasing to be itself. Chapter 10 states that humanism systematically.



PART TWO

Readings

4 · The Chiasmus of Mortality

5 · Felicitous Misfire

6 · Katabasis and Carnival

7 · The Two Brides

8 · Pharmakon

9 · Psyche, Pupa, Imago

CHAPTER FOUR

The Chiasmus of Mortality: Coverture, Civil Death, and the Grey Economy

4

In the world the film depicts, the boundary between the living and the dead is drawn by law and economy before it is drawn by biology. The chromatic inversion of the two worlds, grey above and incandescent below, is the visible form of a juridical fact: in the eyes of the law, the Victorian bride was already a corpse.

4.1 *The butterfly under glass*

The film opens on an act of release. Victor, at a window above the grey town, completes a drawing of a blue butterfly held beneath a glass dome, then lifts the dome and lets the insect go. The prologue is an emblem of the film's ethics, and its full meaning appears only at the end, when a woman becomes a cloud of such butterflies. Between the two releases the film traverses a world organized around the opposite gesture: capture, preservation, display.

The image has a twentieth-century literary genealogy that sharpens its stakes. In John Fowles's *The Collector* (1963), a lepidopterist abducts an art student and keeps her until she dies, loving her as he loves his specimens, by possessing her. Sylvia Plath's *The Bell Jar* (1963) makes the glass dome the emblem of a femininity suffocated by the expectation of marriage. Eliot's Prufrock, fixed by the formulating gaze, imagines himself pinned and wriggling on a wall. Against these figures the prologue offers a man who studies the butterfly closely enough to draw it and then declines to keep it. Victor is an anti-collector.

His name sharpens the point. The most famous Victor of the Gothic is Mary Shelley's Victor Frankenstein, who assembles a female companion for his creature and tears her apart before she can be animated, for fear of what a woman with a will of her own might do; his own bride, Elizabeth, is murdered by the creature on

their wedding night. Shelley's Victor makes a bride and destroys her. Victor Van Dort releases a captive in his first scene and is himself released, in the last, by a bride he did not make. Mary Shelley was the daughter of Mary Wollstonecraft, and the line from the *Vindication* through *Frankenstein* to *Corpse Bride* is a single, continuous reflection on what men make of women and what women make of themselves.

4.2 *Two houses, one transaction*

The plot begins as a merger. The Van Dorts are fish merchants who have made a fortune and lack standing; the Everglots possess an ancient name and an empty treasury. The marriage of their children converts money into title and title into money, and the opening musical number, in which both households set out their designs, establishes calculation as the native grammar of the living world. The parents do not sing of their children's happiness. They sing of the plan.

The *Communist Manifesto* (1848) describes this world exactly: the bourgeoisie has torn the sentimental veil from the family and "reduced the family relation to a mere money relation." Engels's *Origin of the Family, Private Property and the State* (1884) generalizes the point, arguing that monogamous marriage arose as an institution for the transmission of private property and that the first class oppression coincided with the subjection of women within it. Terry Eagleton's reading of Richardson's *Clarissa* (1982) supplies the closest literary precedent: a bourgeois family pursuing aristocratic consolidation through a daughter's body, an aristocratic libertine who preys upon her, and a heroine whose only sovereign act is her death. Austen's *Pride and Prejudice* (1813) turns on an estate entailed away from daughters by a dead ancestor's settlement, and on Charlotte Lucas's lucid acceptance of a marriage of prudence.

The Everglots' decay is inscribed in their names. Finis, the father's name, is Latin for the end: the line has outlived its means and persists only as form. The ancestral portraits of the Everglot house are the family's last capital, images of the dead that authorize the living. Chapter 9 connects them to the Roman *imagines*, the wax masks by which noble families let their dead govern the present.

4.3 *Coverture and civil death*

The legal frame of this transaction was coverture. Blackstone's *Commentaries on the Laws of England* (1765) states the doctrine: by marriage husband and wife become one person in law, so that "the very being or legal existence of the woman is suspended during the marriage," incorporated into that of her husband. A married woman could not, in her own name, hold most property, make contracts, or sue, and could generally make a will only with her husband's assent. The Seneca Falls Declaration of Sentiments (1848) drew the conclusion in the vocabulary that gives this chapter its thesis: "He has made her, if married, in the eye of the law, civilly dead."

The English campaign against coverture unfolded across the decades the film evokes. Caroline Norton, deprived of her children and her earnings by a husband the law empowered, published *English Laws for Women in the Nineteenth Century* (1854); in the same year Barbara Leigh Smith set out the laws concerning women in plain language for those subject to them. Harriet Taylor's "The Enfranchisement of Women" (1851) and John Stuart Mill's *The Subjection of Women* (1869), which called the wife "the actual bond-servant of her husband," supplied the philosophical case. The Married Women's Property Acts of 1870 and 1882 dismantled the doctrine's economic core.

The liturgy exposes the contradiction at the heart of the doctrine. In the marriage service of the 1662 Book of Common Prayer, the man declares that he endows his bride with all his worldly goods at the very moment the law transfers hers to him. The words of the vow perform a gift; the law performs an expropriation. Carole Pateman's *The Sexual Contract* (1988) gives the structural account: the social contract of liberal theory presupposed a prior sexual contract establishing men's sexual access to women's bodies and their authority over women's persons, and the marriage contract is its paradigm. Kant's classification of marriage under a right to a person akin to a right over things, discussed in Chapter 3, is the philosophical form of the same arrangement.

The common law gave that contract its starkest form. Sir Matthew Hale's *History of the Pleas of the Crown* (1736) held that a husband could not be guilty of raping his wife, because by marrying she had given herself to him in a way "which she cannot retract." The exemption stood in England and Wales until the House of Lords abolished it in *R v R* (1991). Hale's doctrine is the juridical form of an unremittable vow: consent given once, at the altar, which the law forbade the woman ever to withdraw. It is the exact antithesis of the remissive performative this dissertation describes, and the plainest evidence that the Victorian bride's civil death extended to her body.

Hence the chiasmus. Victoria Everglot, alive, is a bride on her way into civil death: her will is about to be absorbed, her person is already the object of a transaction, and her consent has been presumed by her parents and will be enforced by her pastor. Emily, dead, holds a vow, pursues a claim, recaptures a fleeing husband, contests the jurisprudence of her elders, and finally disposes of her claim by an act that is, in the strict sense, testamentary. The film's corpse bride is the only woman in it who is not civilly dead.

4.4 *The disciplined body*

The film renders civil death in the body. Victoria is laced into a corset at her mother's command; her posture, her speech, and her silences are supervised; music is forbidden her as improper and too passionate for a young lady. Michel Foucault's analysis of the docile body produced by discipline (*Discipline and Punish*, 1975), extended to femininity by Sandra Lee Bartky (1988) and Susan Bordo (*Unbearable Weight*, 1993), describes this regime precisely: the female body is trained into a self-surveilling form whose constraint is experienced as propriety.

The prohibition of music inverts a famous feminist argument in an instructive way. Wollstonecraft's *Vindication of the Rights of Woman* (1792) attacked the accomplishments, music, drawing, and dancing, as ornaments by which girls were trained to catch husbands, and protested that women's persons were thereby "often legally prostituted." Maudeline Everglot forbids music not because it is ornamental but because it is expressive. What the living world fears is not frivolity but passion, and what it suppresses is not decoration but voice. Rousseau's portrait of Sophie in *Émile* (1762), educated to please and to be useful to a man, is the ideal Maudeline enforces, stripped of Rousseau's sentiment.

Victoria is also confined. When she escapes through her window to report the truth of Victor's disappearance to the pastor, he returns her to her parents, who lock her in her room and arrange her marriage to the first apparently rich stranger to present himself. The sequence compresses the plots of Wollstonecraft's *Maria, or the Wrongs of Woman* (1798), in which a husband confines his wife to an asylum to seize her fortune, and Charlotte Perkins Gilman's "The Yellow Wallpaper" (1892), in which a wife's confinement is administered as care. Maudeline's dismissal of the question whether the betrothed will even like one another, answered by citing her own loveless marriage as the norm, completes the picture: affection is not a condition of marriage but an impropriety within it. Coventry Patmore's *The Angel in the House* (1854–62) named the ideal, and Virginia Woolf's "Professions for Women" (1931) described the necessity of killing it.

Victoria is nevertheless not merely a victim. She is the first character in the film to choose Victor, the first to act on the truth about his disappearance, and the only

living character who breaches her confinement in order to help someone else. The film distributes agency to both brides. It shows that the living world nullifies the agency of the one and the dead world honors the agency of the other.

4.5 *Grey*

The palette of the living world, slate, pewter, charcoal, and the desaturated blue of a winter afternoon, is the visible form of civil death. The architecture compresses its inhabitants under steep roofs and narrow verticals descended from Expressionist design, schedules regulate movement, and the town crier circulates news as Heidegger's "they" circulates idle talk, in which everything is known and nothing understood. The living have expelled death from their world, in the manner Ariès calls forbidden death, and have become deathly in consequence. Ernest Becker's account of immortality projects explains their fixation on lineage and rank: status is a defence against mortality, and a world organized by that defence must deny the dead any presence except as portraits. The film's chromatic joke, that the dead are more colorful than the living, is a precise diagnosis. A culture that cannot look at death cannot look at life either.

4.6 *The pastor and the form*

Pastor Galswells, voiced by Christopher Lee with the authority of Hammer's Count, guards the form of the vow. He demands perfect recitation, halts the ceremony at the first failure, and treats correct execution as the substance of marriage. He also returns the fugitive daughter to her parents. The church of the living is the institutional seat of the dead hand: the custodian of forms that bind persons to arrangements made by others.

4.7 *The two mortmains*

English law had a precise term for the hold of the dead and the undying over the living. The Statute of Mortmain (1279) restricted grants of land to ecclesiastical corporations, which never died and therefore held land in a dead hand, outside the cycle of inheritance. The fee tail created by *De donis* (1285) allowed a settlor to bind the descent of an estate across generations, and the rule against perpetuities, settled after the Duke of Norfolk's Case (1682), was the law's attempt to limit how long the dead may govern property. The Everglot match is a transaction under mortmain: two families dispose of their children according to the requirements of lineage and capital, the dead authority of a name and the undying authority of money.

Against this figurative dead hand the film raises a literal one. The hand that emerges from the forest floor is the dead hand in person, and the plot will show it to be less deadly than the institution that shares its name. The literal mortmain will undo the figurative one.

The chiasmus can be stated in the terms of Martha Nussbaum's central capabilities, the thresholds below which a human life falls short of dignity. The result is a ledger in which the living hold the first capability and almost none of the rest, while the dead lack the first and exercise nearly all the others.

Central capability	Land of the Living	Land of the Dead
Life	Held	Forfeited
Bodily health	Held, under the corset	Moot: bodies come apart without harm
Bodily integrity	Breached by confinement and an arranged match	Free movement and choice of partner
Senses, imagination, thought	Disciplined; music forbidden	Exercised in music, invention, storytelling
Emotions	Suppressed; affection deemed irrelevant to marriage	Expressed in lament, laughter, love
Practical reason	Ceded to parents and pastor	Exercised in the Elder's jurisprudence and Emily's choice
Affiliation	Governed by rank	Egalitarian *communitas*
Other species	A butterfly kept under glass	A dog, a spider, a maggot as companions
Play	Forbidden as improper	Constant
Control over one's environment	Property without freedom; daughters without property	Freedom without property

The ledger states the chiasmus in its sharpest form. Life, the first capability, is the only one the living have and the only one the dead lack. A humanism that measured dignity by biological life alone would have to rank the grey town above the Land of the Dead. The film's wager, and this dissertation's, is that such a humanism has mistaken a condition of dignity for its content.

CHAPTER FIVE

Felicitous Misfire: The Vow and the Theory of the Performative

5

The film is a fable about performative utterance whose plot can be stated in Austin's own terms. A vow misfires when performed in its proper setting, succeeds when rehearsed in soliloquy, binds across death in defiance of the conditions that should void it, and is finally undone by an act the theory of the performative has not named.

5.1 *Austin's paradigm*

Austin's William James Lectures, delivered at Harvard in 1955 and published as *How to Do Things with Words* (1962), distinguish constative utterances, which describe and may be true or false, from performative utterances, which do what they say and may be felicitous or infelicitous. The first example Austin gives is a bridegroom's assent in the marriage ceremony; the third is a bequest in a will. *Corpse Bride* travels from Austin's first example to his third: it opens with a marriage vow and closes with a testamentary act. The editors of the lectures record a further irony. Austin learned too late that the Anglican rite has the bridegroom answer "I will," not "I do," and the error was left standing as philosophically unimportant. The paradigm case of performative theory is itself a citation of a ceremony as remembered rather than as written, which is exactly the condition of the vow Victor speaks in the forest.

Austin specifies the conditions under which a performative succeeds. There must be an accepted conventional procedure with a conventional effect; the persons and circumstances must be appropriate to it; it must be executed correctly and completely; and the participants must have the requisite thoughts and intentions and conduct themselves accordingly afterward. Failures of the first four kinds are misfires, and the act is void. Failures of the last two are abuses: the act is performed but hollow, as when one promises insincerely.

Two further features of Austin's account matter here. In his first lecture he refuses the excuse of Euripides' Hippolytus, whose tongue swore while his heart did not; accuracy and morality alike, Austin holds, side with the plain view that our word is our bond. In his second, he sets aside utterances made by an actor on a stage, introduced in a poem, or spoken in soliloquy, as hollow, parasitic upon normal use, and outside his inquiry.

5.2 *The rehearsal as misfire*

The rehearsal sequence satisfies every condition of the first kind. The procedure is the accepted rite; the persons are the betrothed; the circumstances include an ordained pastor and assembled families who stand as witnesses. It fails on execution. Victor cannot complete the formula: the words desert him, the ring falls, and the candle he holds sets his future mother-in-law's dress alight. The pastor halts the procedure and sends him away to learn his vows. By Austin's taxonomy the act misfires and is void.

The comedy is also an analysis. The rite is indifferent to the only sincere thing about the occasion: minutes earlier, at the piano, Victor and Victoria began to fall in love. The institution measures marriage by correct execution and finds the young man wanting, while the feelings Austin's last conditions require are present and unconsulted. Victor's failure can be read with Jack Halberstam's *The Queer Art of Failure* (2011) as the film's first resistance: an inability to perform the competent bourgeois masculinity the ceremony demands, which opens a space the institution cannot govern.

5.3 *The soliloquy as felicitous parasite*

In the forest, alone, Victor rehearses until the vow comes fluently and fervently. This is the case Austin excluded: an utterance in soliloquy, uttered as practice, addressed to no one. It is also the only utterance in the film that binds.

Derrida's “Signature Event Context” (1971) argued that Austin's exclusion cannot hold. A formula can function as a performative only because it is iterable: repeatable in other contexts, citable, detachable from any single intention. The possibility Austin quarantined as parasitic is the structural condition of every performative. John Searle's reply (1977) restored intention as the criterion that separates serious from non-serious speech, and Derrida's rejoinder, “Limited Inc,” pressed the point that no context can be saturated enough to exclude citation.

The film adjudicates the dispute in Derrida's favor and, more surprisingly, in favor of Austin's own dictum against Hippolytus. Victor's tongue swore; his heart did not; the word binds him. In this the film is as formalist as the Jewish tale it

adapts, where a jest, properly formed and witnessed, binds. Judith Butler's *Excitable Speech* (1997) explains why. The force of a performative does not issue from the sovereign intention of a speaker but from the sedimented history of its citations: an utterance works because it repeats countless prior utterances that have made it authoritative. In the forest Victor does not speak in his own voice but in the voice of every wedding the formula has ever sealed. The institution therefore binds even where the person did not intend it.

Two further conditions are met in the forest that were absent at the rehearsal. The first is uptake. Austin held that an illocution must be heard and understood to be achieved, and in the forest it is: a hearer answers. Emily's assent completes the procedure, and the forest vow becomes a contract only when the woman speaks. The consensualist canon law reviewed below held exactly this, that marriage is made by the consent of both parties.

The second is witnessing. Eve Kosofsky Sedgwick observed that Austin's examples cluster around the marriage ceremony, and drew attention to the witnesses whom the ceremony conscripts into its authority and whose silence ratifies the union. The rehearsal had living witnesses who withheld ratification. The forest has the dead, who will celebrate the marriage with a feast.

5.4 *The vow's figures literalized*

The vow Victor perfects is composed of four emblems, each attached to a promise: a hand that will relieve grief; a cup that will never be empty because the speaker will be its wine; a candle that will light the beloved's way through darkness; and a ring by which he asks her to be his. Todorov observed that the fantastic often begins when a figurative expression is taken literally. The plot of *Corpse Bride* is the literal execution of its vow.

The hand becomes the dead hand that rises from the earth to receive the ring. The candle becomes Victor's passage through the dark of the underworld, and before that the flame that set a dress alight. The cup becomes the Wine of Ages, by which he would become, literally, the content of the dead bride's cup. The ring becomes the token whose return ends the story.

The vow is thus the generative matrix of the narrative, and the film's deepest formal principle follows from it: what the living say in figures, the dead take at their word. The living world speaks a liturgy it does not mean; the dead world holds it to its meaning, and it is by being held to its words that the living world is finally released from them.

5.5 *A history of consent*

The history of marriage formation shows how exact the film's legal imagination is. Gratian's *Decretum* (c. 1140) held that marriage was initiated by consent and completed by consummation. Peter Lombard's *Sentences* distinguished consent in words of the present tense, which made a marriage, from words of the future tense, which made only a betrothal. The decretals of Pope Alexander III (1159–81) settled the canon law of the Latin West: present consent sufficed, and future consent followed by intercourse also made a marriage. Clandestine marriages were illicit but valid. In medieval Europe two persons could marry each other alone, with words, in a field.

The Council of Trent's decree *Tametsi* (1563) made the presence of the parish priest and witnesses a condition of validity for Catholics. In England, Lord Hardwicke's Marriage Act (1753) required banns or licence, an Anglican ceremony, and parental consent for minors. Its purpose was to end clandestine marriage, and a principal motive was the protection of heirs and heiresses from fortune hunters; eloping couples fled across the border to Gretna Green, where the act did not run.

Emily's history, as the dead tell it, is precisely the case the act was written for: a daughter planning a secret flight with a stranger her father disapproved of, carrying her family's valuables, betrayed and killed by a fortune hunter. The law's paternal protection and the father's control over his daughter's marriage are two faces of the same dead hand, and neither protected her.

The forest marriage is void under the law of the living: no priest, no banns, no living witnesses. Under the superseded consensualist law of the medieval Church, words of present consent exchanged between two parties make a marriage. The Land of the Dead runs on dead law. The same is true of the Jewish frame the adaptation effaced, in which a ring and a formula before witnesses make a betrothal whatever the parties feel. The film's underworld is a jurisdiction of abrogated codes, and its plot asks what such codes owe the living.

5.6 *The jurisprudence of the Elder*

Every Christian marriage vow carries its own term. The 1662 service binds the spouses “till death us do part,” a phrase that popular usage has rearranged into a more familiar order. A vow made to someone already dead is therefore self-cancelling: its term has expired before it was made. Elder Gutknecht, the jurist of the dead, recognizes this. The forest vow cannot hold in death because the vow itself places its limit at death. To give it force, the living groom must repeat the vow in the Land of the Living and then die, by drinking the Wine of Ages.

The remedy discloses something about adjudication in this film. The law of the dead, too, demands the body of the living; it is a mortmain of its own. Neither the pastor nor the Elder can produce a release that preserves both parties. The pastor can only void a defective performance, and the Elder can only complete a valid one at the cost of a life. Authority in *Corpse Bride* enforces form. It cannot give.

5.7 *Five exits from a vow, and a sixth act*

There are five ordinary ways out of a vow, and the film shows each. Fulfillment discharges the obligation by performing it; here fulfillment is possible only through the groom's death. Annulment is a competent authority's declaration that no valid bond arose; this was the rabbinic court's remedy, and it is the remedy the pastor applies to the rehearsal. Breach is violation by a party who treats the vow as an instrument; it is Barkis's method, who marries to rob. Dissolution by term is the vow's own expiry clause, death, on which the Elder's reasoning turns. Repudiation is unilateral flight; Victor attempts it and is recaptured.

The film's resolution is none of these. It is an act by which the holder of a valid claim extinguishes it freely and gratuitously, addressed to and received by the party bound. This dissertation calls it the *remissive performative*. Like every performative it does what it says: the claim does not lapse but is released. Its conditions of felicity can be stated in Austin's manner. The remitter must hold the claim (standing); must act without coercion (freedom); must know what she releases and to whom (knowledge); must neither demand nor expect a counter-performance (gratuity); and must address the release to the party released, who receives it (uptake). Chapter 10 develops the definition.

The act has legal and historical analogues that clarify its form. At common law the release of a debt without consideration required a deed under seal. Pinnel's Case (1602) held that payment of a lesser sum could not satisfy a greater debt, though “the gift of a horse, hawk, or robe” could. The ring, which as a signet once sealed deeds, is the seal of Emily's release. A closer prototype is the statement John Stuart Mill wrote in 1851, on the eve of his marriage to Harriet Taylor, formally protesting the powers the law of marriage would confer on him over her and promising never to use them. Mill's statement is a husband's remission of rights the law gave him. Emily's act is its mirror: a bride's remission of a right the vow gave her.

Remission must finally be distinguished from forgiveness. Arendt's forgiveness, and Derrida's aporetic forgiveness of the unforgivable, address a wrong. Remission addresses a right. Emily does not forgive Barkis, whose crime is judged. She releases Victor, who has wronged her only by carelessness and by flight. Her

release includes a pardon, but its essence is the surrender of a valid claim against someone who is, in the decisive sense, innocent.

CHAPTER SIX

Katabasis and Carnival: The Land of the Dead as Counter-World

The descent into the Land of the Dead follows the oldest plot in Western literature, the katabasis, and inverts its valuation. The underworld is not a place of shades who envy the living but a commonwealth that possesses what the living lack, and the climax is not the hero's return from below but the ascent of the dead to the surface.

6.1 *Descent*

In the eleventh book of the *Odyssey*, the shade of Achilles tells Odysseus that he would rather labor as a hired hand for a landless man than rule over all the dead. The Homeric underworld is privation: bloodless shades who must drink sacrificial blood to speak. In the sixth book of the *Aeneid*, Dido's shade meets Aeneas in silence and turns from him to her first husband, Sychaeus; the abandoned woman's dignity in the underworld is the refusal of speech. Emily's dignity, by contrast, is speech. She reproaches, argues, sings, and judges.

The katabasis of a musician to recover a dead bride is the myth of Orpheus and Eurydice (Virgil, *Georgics* IV; Ovid, *Metamorphoses* X), and modern feminist poetics rewrote it from the bride's side. In Rilke's "Orpheus. Eurydike. Hermes." (1904), Eurydice walks behind her husband so full of her own death that she no longer belongs to him, and when the god tells her that Orpheus has turned, she does not know whom he means. H.D.'s "Eurydice" (1917) gives the dead bride a voice of reproach against the arrogance of the poet who lost her and claims for her a light of her own. Carol Ann Duffy's "Eurydice" (1999) imagines a woman who contrives to be lost rather than return to life as a poet's muse. *Corpse Bride* realigns the myth with these revisions. The musician descends; the dead bride plays better than he does; and it is she who finally sends him back to the living, by choice, without a backward look that destroys.

The Homeric *Hymn to Demeter* supplies a second pattern. Persephone is seized into the underworld as the bride of Hades and bound to it by the pomegranate seeds she eats, until a settlement among the gods restores her to the upper world for part of each year. Victor is a male Kore: a youth taken below by a bride, bound by a token, and released by negotiation. Hades bore the cult name Plouton, the wealthy one, because the riches of the earth lie beneath it, and the Land of the Dead is the only rich place in the film. Its wealth is color, music, and company, set against an aristocracy above that is bankrupt in every sense.

The descent also has a ritual logic. Van Gennep's rites of passage move through separation, a liminal phase, and incorporation. Victor's descent occurs on the eve of an arranged wedding, and the film displaces the liminal phase of the marriage rite underground, where it can transform what the official rite merely administers.

6.2 *Carnival and the archive of the ungrieved*

Bakhtin's carnival is visible in every frame below ground: hierarchies inverted, the grotesque body celebrated, laughter that renews. A skeletal general with a Napoleonic name, a disembodied head who waits on tables, a bride whose arm comes away in a lover's grip: dismemberment becomes slapstick, and death becomes what Bakhtin calls pregnant death, death bound to renewal.

The most consequential carnival act is the ballad. Emily's history is sung by a skeletal bandleader as a swing number in a tavern: her love for a stranger, the planned elopement, the wedding dress and family valuables, the night-time wait by a tree, the murder, and her vow to wait for a true love. The form converts tragedy into entertainment and terror into rhythm. It also performs a function no institution of the living ever performed: it remembers. Judith Butler's analysis of grievability, in *Precarious Life* (2004) and *Frames of War* (2009), asks whose lives are recognized as lives whose loss would count as a loss. Emily's death, in a forest, unrecorded, its murderer free, was ungrieved by the living. The dead grieve it in song.

The ballad also gives Emily what Adriana Cavarero calls a narratable self. In *Relating Narratives* (1997), Cavarero argues, extending Arendt, that the unity of a life is given by the story another tells of it, and that each of us desires to hear our own story told by someone else. The ballad tells Emily's story while she is present to hear it. The dead constitute an archive of the ungrieved and a chorus that confers identity on those the living world erased.

6.3 *Communitas and the equalization of things*

Turner opposed *communitas*, the egalitarian bond of liminal states, to structure, the differentiated order of positions. The Land of the Dead is communitas institutionalized. Rank persists only as a joke, in the general whose dignity is comic, while the actual social order is convivial and level. Zhuangzi's equalization of things describes the same condition from another tradition: once the distinction between life and death has lost its absoluteness, the distinctions of rank lose theirs as well.

The counter-world can also be read through the left-Hegelian critique of religion. For Feuerbach the afterlife is the projection of an essence that earthly life withholds; for the young Marx, religion is the heart of a heartless world. The Land of the Dead is the projected heart of the grey town: everything the living have alienated, music, conviviality, the freedom to feel and to say what one feels, has been deposited below. Ernst Bloch's *The Principle of Hope* (1954–59) would call it a utopian surplus, the anticipation of a not-yet carried by fairy tales, festivals, and above all music. Sartre's *No Exit* imagined the dead locked in a room where other people are hell. *Corpse Bride* imagines the dead in a tavern where other people are consolation.

6.4 *Sonic politics*

Elfman's score divides the film into two musical worlds, and the music of the dead has a precise cinematic genealogy. Ub Iwerks animated Disney's *The Skeleton Dance* (1929), the founding skeletal dance of animated film. The Fleischer studio's *Minnie the Moocher* (1932) and *Snow-White* (1933) rotoscoped Cab Calloway's singing and movement onto a ghostly walrus and onto a spectral figure performing "St. James Infirmary Blues." Bonejangles, the skeletal bandleader who sings Emily's ballad, is a Calloway figure: master of ceremonies, scat phrasing, swing. His name evokes both the song "Mr. Bojangles" and the dancer Bill "Bojangles" Robinson.

A full account of the film's humanism must register what this genealogy implies. The film codes the vitality of the dead through African American musical idiom, performed by a white composer, in a world otherwise wholly white. Eric Lott's *Love and Theft* (1993) describes the relation of white American culture to Black performance as a compound of desire and expropriation, and the Fleischer cartoons placed Calloway's genius among ghosts and grotesques. The film inherits that ambivalence. Black music is the sound of liberation, and it is also assigned to the dead. The utopia below borrows its life from a culture the film never represents. Chapter 10 treats this as a limit the film's humanism does not overcome.

6.5 *Anabasis*

The film's climax reverses the direction of the katabasis: the dead ascend. When they emerge into the streets to attend the wedding, the living flee in terror. Then recognition breaks through, and spouses, parents, children, and descendants reunite. Terror becomes joy because the dead turn out to be one's own.

The scene condenses the Mexican Día de Muertos, an institution of annual return in which the dead visit kin who have prepared for them. It also enacts what Robert Hertz described as the final ceremony of double obsequies, which incorporates the dead among the ancestors and frees the living from mourning. Twentieth-century grief theory, following Freud's "Mourning and Melancholia," long held that healthy mourning required the withdrawal of attachment from the dead; the continuing-bonds model developed by Dennis Klass, Phyllis Silverman, and Steven Nickman (1996) argues instead that sustained relationship with the dead is normal and often sustaining. The anabasis is a continuing-bonds image.

Walter Benjamin's second thesis on the concept of history speaks of a secret agreement between past generations and the present one, and of a weak messianic power with which the present is endowed and to which the past has a claim. The ascent of the dead is the collection of that claim, and it is collected in joy. It also completes the left-Hegelian reversal: the heart deposited below returns to the heartless world.

6.6 *The limits of carnival and the green world*

Terry Eagleton warned that carnival is a licensed affair, a permitted rupture of hegemony that strengthens what it briefly suspends. The dead go back below. Does the film's carnival change anything?

It does, because the anabasis produces a juridical event. The predator is exposed and judged; the dead bride's claim is heard and then remitted; the arranged match is replaced by a chosen union. These events alter the settlement of the living world without abolishing it. The families and their ranks remain, and the change is partial. Chapter 10 returns to this residue.

Northrop Frye described Shakespearean comedy as a movement from the harsh law of an old society, through a green world of transformation, back to a renewed society. A *Midsummer Night's Dream* opens with a father invoking the ancient privilege of Athens over his daughter: "As she is mine, I may dispose of her." The duke offers her the father's choice, death, or the cloister, a life spent "Chanting faint hymns to the cold fruitless moon." In *Corpse Bride* the green world is the underworld, and the moon returns at the end as the horizon toward which a freed

woman rises. It is no longer the barren moon of the cloister but the moon of a woman who has left the market of marriage on her own terms.

Stanley Cavell's comedies of remarriage supply the last element. In films such as *The Philadelphia Story* and *The Awful Truth*, a couple must separate and return in order to make a marriage that is chosen rather than imposed, and the sign of its legitimacy is conversation between equals. Victor and Victoria are both, in this sense, remarried. Each has a first marriage, his to Emily and hers to Barkis, that is dissolved, the one by remission and the other by death. Their union becomes a marriage whose authority rests on choice rather than on contract.

CHAPTER SEVEN

7

The Two Brides: Doubling, Abjection, and the Sororal Transaction

The film's central relation is not between the groom and either bride but between the two brides. Its climax converts the oldest rivalry of the marriage plot, two women for one man, into a transaction between women in which the man is the object transferred and the medium of exchange is a gift.

7.1 *Names*

Victor and Victoria are mirror names, and the mirroring is a diagnosis: the arranged couple is a symmetry produced by design, the bourgeois match as narcissistic reflection. Blake Edwards's *Victor/Victoria* (1982), in which a woman performs a man performing a woman, had already made the pairing a figure for gender as performance. Victoria is also the name of the age the film evokes. Queen Victoria's white wedding dress of 1840 established the white wedding as a norm, and her mourning for Albert, from 1861 until her death in 1901, made widowhood a national style. The great age of what Ariès calls "thy death," of the beloved dead cultivated in memorial jewelry, photography, and black crape, was named for its most famous mourner.

Emily derives from the Latin *Aemilius*, traditionally, if uncertainly, associated with *aemulus*, rival. The name assigns her the position the marriage plot reserves for her, the rival bride. It also places her in a lineage of literary Emilys wedded to death. Emily Brontë's *Wuthering Heights* (1847) gives the revenant bride at the window, Catherine's ghost begging admission in Lockwood's dream, and the lover who arranges to be buried beside her with the adjoining sides of their coffins removed so that their dust may mingle: love consummated in decomposition. Emily Dickinson's "Because I could not stop for Death" (written c. 1863, published

1890) is a courtship poem in which Death is a courteous gentleman caller, the speaker is dressed in gossamer and tulle, and the carriage ride ends at a house that is a swelling of the ground. William Faulkner's "A Rose for Emily" (1930) gives the darkest member of the line: a woman who buys arsenic, whose suitor disappears, and in whose sealed upper room the townspeople find, decades later, his body in a bridal chamber with the indentation of a head and a strand of her grey hair on the pillow beside him: for years she had lain beside the corpse. Emily Grierson keeps the groom by killing him, with arsenic as the story implies, and keeps the marriage by lying beside his body, a necrophilic possession the story discloses only in its final lines.

The Emily of *Corpse Bride* stands at the end of this line and repudiates its solution. The Wine of Ages is Emily Grierson's arsenic, offered this time with the groom's consent, and refused by the bride.

A further onomastic shadow falls from Rousseau. *Émile* (1762) is the education of a man for freedom, and its fifth book educates Sophie for Émile. Emily is what becomes of a woman who chose for herself in a world that had educated her as Sophie: she is killed for it, and in death completes the education in freedom that Rousseau reserved for the man.

7.2 *Angel and monster*

Sandra Gilbert and Susan Gubar's *The Madwoman in the Attic* (1979) argued that the nineteenth-century literary imagination split woman into angel and monster, and that the madwoman, Bertha Mason in *Jane Eyre* above all, is the monstrous double through whom suppressed female rage is both expressed and destroyed. *Corpse Bride* appears to repeat the structure: a pale, obedient, living angel; a passionate, grotesque, dead monster; a man between them; and the monster's removal clears the way for marriage. Jean Rhys's *Wide Sargasso Sea* (1966) rewrote Bertha from within, as a woman made mad by a marriage that dispossessed her. The film's difference from Brontë is the difference Rhys demanded. The monster is given her history, and her removal is not a burning in an attic but a departure she chooses after her history is told and her wrong is judged. She leaves the angel her blessing.

Poe's "Ligeia" (1838) is the film's most exact negative. The narrator's first wife, dark, learned, and passionate, dies; he marries the fair Lady Rowena, whose haughty family consented to the match "through thirst of gold"; Rowena sickens and dies, and her corpse revives as Ligeia. The tale's epigraph, attributed to Joseph Glanvill but never found in his works, declares that man yields to death "only through the weakness of his feeble will." Ligeia's triumph is the will's victory over death, achieved by consuming the living bride. Emily's triumph is the inverse: the

dead bride yields her will so that the living bride may live. *Corpse Bride* is an anti-Ligeia.

E. T. A. Hoffmann's "The Sandman" (1816) supplies another negative. Nathanael abandons his living fiancée Clara for Olimpia, an automaton who answers him only with sighs and whose perfection mirrors his narcissism. Emily, a puppet among puppets, is the opposite of Olimpia. She speaks, argues, refuses, and judges, and the man who might have made her his mirror is instead given back to himself.

Daphne du Maurier's *Rebecca* (1938) offers the configuration in its modern form: a dead first wife dominates a nameless living second, and the husband is revealed as the first wife's killer. Hitchcock's film of 1940, constrained by the Production Code, converted the killing into an accident. *Corpse Bride* reproduces du Maurier's configuration exactly, since the living bride is married, for a few hours, to the murderer of the dead bride. Its difference is that the dead bride exposes the murderer and frees the living bride from him.

The fairy-tale form of this configuration is Bluebeard. In Perrault's tale (1697) a new wife opens a forbidden chamber, finds the bodies of the wives her husband has murdered, and is saved by her brothers, who kill him. Angela Carter's "The Bloody Chamber" (1979) gave the rescue to the heroine's mother, who rides in and shoots the Marquis, and Maria Tatar (2004) and Marina Warner (1994) have traced the tale's long service as a narrative of marital knowledge and its dangers. *Corpse Bride* completes the feminist revision of Bluebeard: the rescue comes from a sister. A dead wife steps out of the chamber to save the living one.

The film also answers Freud. "The Theme of the Three Caskets" (1913) argued that stories in which a man chooses among women conceal the necessity of death: the third and silent woman is Death, transformed by wish into the most beautiful and the freely chosen. Victor's situation literalizes Freud's thesis, since he must choose between a living bride and Death in a wedding dress. But the film reverses Freud's reversal. Death does not disguise herself as the most desirable woman in order to be chosen. She is the one who chooses, and she chooses life for the man and for the other woman.

7.3 *Abjection reversed*

Julia Kristeva's *Powers of Horror* (1980) identifies the corpse as the utmost of abjection, that which disturbs identity, system, and order and must be expelled for the subject to constitute itself. Barbara Creed's *The Monstrous-Feminine* (1993) showed how horror cinema figures the female body as abject: the archaic mother, the witch, the vampire, the possessed woman. Emily's first appearance is staged in exactly that grammar: moonlight, a veil, a skeletal hand, a figure rising from the ground in a decayed wedding dress, and a man who flees. The film then reverses the coding. The abject body becomes the locus of tenderness, wit, and moral authority, and the man who fled from her will owe her his life.

Mary Russo's *The Female Grotesque* (1994) recovers the grotesque body as a resource, a body that exceeds its frame and so escapes the frame's discipline. Kathleen Rowe's *The Unruly Woman* (1995) reads female excess, looseness, and laughter as power. Emily's grotesque features are comic, and she shares the joke: an eye that pops from its socket, an arm that detaches, a body that cannot be harmed. The abject becomes comic, and therefore free.

The maggot who lives in her head deserves attention as a figure. In Poe's "The Conqueror Worm," the poem Ligeia composes on her deathbed, the worm is the hero of the tragedy called Man. In Blake's "The Sick Rose" (1794), an invisible worm finds out the rose's "bed / Of crimson joy" and destroys it with "dark secret love." *Corpse Bride* moves the worm from the bed to the head. It does not consume; it comments, a sardonic conscience whose voice is borrowed from the old horror cinema. Death's agent becomes a companion, and the corruption of the bridal body becomes a source of advice.

7.4 *The dead beautiful woman*

Poe's "The Philosophy of Composition" (1846) declared the death of a beautiful woman to be "unquestionably, the most poetical topic in the world." Elisabeth Bronfen's *Over Her Dead Body* (1992) showed what that dictum performs. Western representation uses the dead beautiful woman to figure death as other, feminine, and aesthetically containable, securing the position of the surviving and usually male observer. The dead woman is a topic, never a speaker.

Emily breaks the contract. She is a dead beautiful woman who refuses to remain a topic and becomes a speaker, narrated first by others in the ballad and then by her own acts. Yet the film also courts the aesthetic it criticizes. Emily's luminous blue, her slender skeletal grace, and her final dissolution are offered as spectacle, and in the last shots the living couple watch her vanish. Laura Mulvey's account of the woman's to-be-looked-at-ness in classical cinema (1975) applies to those shots.

The dialectic is not resolved here. Chapter 10 argues that what separates the ending from Poe's aesthetic is authorship: the spectators do not watch a woman dying but a woman choosing.

7.5 *The traffic in women and the inverted triangle*

Claude Lévi-Strauss's *The Elementary Structures of Kinship* (1949) made the exchange of women among men, enforced by the incest prohibition, the foundation of kinship and therefore of society: women circulate as gifts and signs among groups of men. Gayle Rubin's "The Traffic in Women" (1975) turned this into a feminist diagnosis of the sex/gender system, and Luce Irigaray's "Women on the Market" (1977) analyzed women as commodities bearing use value and exchange value, the virgin as pure exchange value. Carole Pateman named the political form: the sexual contract.

The film's women are trafficked with unusual explicitness. Victoria is transferred twice, first to the Van Dorts for money and then to Barkis for a fortune he believes she has. Emily was transferred by fraud: her elopement, a bid for freedom, ended with Barkis murdering her and taking the family valuables she had brought for their flight.

Eve Kosofsky Sedgwick's *Between Men* (1985) showed how the canonical erotic triangle uses a woman to mediate a bond between men, and René Girard's *Deceit, Desire and the Novel* (1961) showed how triangular desire breeds rivalry and violence. *Corpse Bride* inverts Sedgwick and refuses Girard. Its triangle places a man between two women, so that he mediates their relation rather than they his, and the rivalry it sets up is resolved not by violence but by recognition.

7.6 *The church: a sororal transaction*

The decisive sequence takes place at the altar. Emily is about to complete the marriage and Victor is about to drink when Emily sees Victoria watching, and stops. She recognizes in the living bride the bride she had been, a woman with hopes of which she was robbed, and she refuses to rob another woman of the future that was taken from her.

The moment can be described in four philosophical vocabularies, and each captures something. In Paul Ricoeur's terms (*Oneself as Another*, 1990), Emily reaches herself by the detour of the other: she understands her own history only when she sees it in another woman's face. In Levinas's terms, the face of the other forbids killing before any argument is made, and here the formula is literal, since the sight of Victoria's face stops a death. In Schopenhauer's terms, compassion is the recognition in another's suffering of one's own being. In Beauvoir's terms,

authentic love rests on the mutual recognition of two freedoms, and Emily recognizes two at once, Victor's and Victoria's. Kierkegaard's work of love is completed in reverse: the dead perform the work of love for the living, who cannot repay them.

Cavarero supplies the most precise frame. *Relating Narratives* recounts the story of two women, Emilia and Amalia, who met in the Italian feminist movement of the 1970s. Emilia asked Amalia again and again to write her life story, and when Amalia did, Emilia carried the text with her and read it, moved. The narratable self needs another to tell its story, and the need is most intense where a life has been denied recognition. The church completes Emily's story in the presence of another woman, who becomes its witness and its continuation.

The transaction itself is composed of two acts. Emily returns the ring to Victor's living hand. Then, at the threshold, she tosses her bouquet back to Victoria. The bouquet toss is the one wedding rite that passes from woman to woman, transmitting a bride's good fortune to the next bride, and here it passes from a dead bride to a living one. The ring returns to the hand, the bouquet passes to the bride, and the giver departs.

The 1662 marriage service asks the question that structures patriarchal marriage: “Who giveth this Woman to be married to this Man?” The answer is a father. In *Corpse Bride* a woman gives the man, and there is no father, pastor, or elder in the transaction at all.

Roman law makes the structure precise. A wife married with *manus* passed into her husband's hand, sometimes by *coemptio*, a fictive sale. *Emancipatio* released a son from his father's power by fictive sales, and *manumissio*, literally a sending from the hand, released a slave; one of its forms was *manumissio testamento*, release by the will of the dead. The hands of *Corpse Bride* trace this whole vocabulary. The dead hand rises from the forest floor (mortmain); the living hand is to receive a bride (*manus*); the arranged match is a *coemptio* between families; and Emily's final act is the release of a man from her hand by an act of will after her death. The dead hand becomes the releasing hand: mortmain becomes *manumissio testamento*.

Irigaray closed “Commodities among Themselves” with a speculation: what if the goods refused to go to market and carried on another kind of exchange among themselves? The church sequence realizes it. Two women, both formerly goods in the market of marriage, transact a man between themselves, outside the paternal market, without a broker, and as a gift.

7.7 *Solidarity and its conditions*

bell hooks warned, in *Feminist Theory: From Margin to Center* (1984) and "Sisterhood: Political Solidarity between Women" (1986), that sisterhood founded on shared victimization is fragile and politically insufficient, and that solidarity must be built across difference by commitment rather than by injury. The two brides share a victimizer: both are brides of Barkis, a sorority of Bluebeard's wives. But the bond the film depicts exceeds shared injury. It is consummated by an asymmetrical gift from the one who has more to lose, a claim, a marriage, a chance at the life denied her, to the one who has more to gain.

Adrienne Rich's "Compulsory Heterosexuality and Lesbian Existence" (1980) proposed what she called a lesbian continuum: a range of woman-identified experience, not confined to sexual relationships, that includes bonds of solidarity, resistance, and mutual recognition between women. The church sequence is the most intense relationship in the film, and the heterosexual frame of the ending visibly strains to contain it. The film resolves a marriage plot, but its ethical climax is a relation between women.

CHAPTER EIGHT

Pharmakon: Justice, Vengeance, and the Wine of Ages

The cup that would have consummated the dead marriage is a *pharmakon*, remedy and poison at once. The film refuses the love-death, refuses sacrifice, and delivers the poison to the guilty man by his own hand, and in doing so it articulates a coherent theory of justice: the victim's release of the innocent is conditional on the judgment of the guilty.

8.1 *The cup*

The cup enters the film in the vow, where the bridegroom promises to be the inexhaustible contents of the beloved's cup, and returns at the climax as the Wine of Ages, a poison that would complete the marriage by killing the groom. In Plato's *Phaedrus* (274e–275b), the god Theuth offers writing to King Thamus as a pharmakon for memory, and the king replies that it is a pharmakon only for reminding. Derrida's "Plato's Pharmacy" (1968) made the word's undecidability, remedy and poison at once, the key to the dialogue, and connected it with the *pharmakos*, the human scapegoat expelled from the Greek city in times of crisis.

The Wine of Ages is a pharmakon in the strict sense. It is a remedy, since it would cure the vow's invalidity and unite the lovers in the only condition in which the vow can hold. It is a poison, since it would kill the groom. The film's crisis is the question of which it will be, and for whom.

Western literature had already set this cup on the altar. Socrates drinks the hemlock with philosophical composure. In *Romeo and Juliet*, Friar Laurence's draught is a pharmakon that counterfeits death in order to save a marriage, and Romeo's poison in the tomb completes the marriage in death. Capulet, believing his daughter dead on her wedding morning, laments: "Death is my son-in-law, Death is my heir; / My daughter he hath wedded." Juliet had foreseen it at their first meeting: "My grave is like to be my wedding bed." The church of *Corpse Bride*

is Juliet's tomb inverted. The bride is truly dead, the groom is alive, and the cup is in his hand.

Wagner's *Tristan und Isolde* (1865) gives the cup its modern metaphysics. Isolde orders a death potion; her servant substitutes a love potion; and the drama ends in a love-death, a transfiguration in which desire is consummated by dissolution. Denis de Rougemont's *L'Amour et l'Occident* (1939) argued that the Western passion-love descended from the Tristan legend secretly desires obstacle and death, and is the enemy of marriage. The Elder's remedy is a love-death by prescription, and Emily refuses it. *Corpse Bride* is in this precise sense anti-Wagnerian. It declines to let love be consummated in death, and finds its resolution not in the unity of lovers in dissolution but in a release that leaves each party free, in their different conditions.

8.2 *Sacrifice refused*

Victor consents to drink. His motives are mixed: despair, since he believes Victoria lost to another man, and honor, since he has given his word. The configuration is a gender-inverted *Alcestis*. In Euripides' play (438 BCE), Apollo has secured for Admetus the right to send a substitute to death in his place; his aged parents refuse; his wife Alcestis consents and dies. Admetus promises never to remarry and to have a likeness of her made to lie beside him, and Heracles wrestles Death and brings her back, veiled and unable to speak until she is purified. Alcestis is the archetype of the sacrificed wife, and feminist readers have noticed that the play rewards her sacrifice with silence.

In *Corpse Bride* the man offers to die so that a woman's claim may be satisfied, and the woman refuses. The refusal has two sides. She refuses to be sacrificed for the order, the fate Catherine Clément traced in *Opera, or the Undoing of Women* (1979), where Carmen, Violetta, Mimì, Isolde, and Butterfly die so that the story may close. And she refuses to be sacrificed to, that is, to be the beneficiary of a death. René Girard's *Violence and the Sacred* (1972) argued that communities discharge accumulated violence onto a victim whose death restores order. The film declines the sacrificial economy in both directions: no woman dies for the order, and no man dies for a woman.

8.3 *Barkis: the pharmakos*

Lord Barkis Bittern arrives at the rehearsal dinner from nowhere, with a title of uncertain warrant and an appetite for fortunes. He is the predator Lord Hardwicke's Act was framed against, Richardson's Lovelace in a cheaper key, and Bluebeard with a single closet. His name joins comedy to menace. In Dickens's *David Copperfield* (1850), Barkis the carrier courts Peggotty with a laconic message of readiness that became proverbial for comic constancy. The bittern is a heron of the reedbeds, concealed by its plumage and known for its booming call. The film's Barkis is a marsh-bird of concealment and noise who wears the name of a faithful suitor.

The climax disposes of him with formal exactness. He seizes Victoria, duels Victor, and is about to kill him when Emily places herself between the blade and its target. Exposed and surrounded by the dead, he raises the cup in mockery of the bride he murdered and drinks. The pharmakon prepared for love kills greed. The dead then claim him as one now subject to their jurisdiction.

Barkis is a pharmakos, the expelled one whose removal purifies the community. But Girard's scapegoat is arbitrary or innocent, and the sacrificial mechanism depends on the community's misrecognition of that innocence. Barkis is guilty, and his expulsion is self-administered. The film refuses the innocent scapegoat: the violence of its climax is not discharged onto a substitute but returns upon its source.

8.4 *Erinys and Eumenis*

Aeschylus' *Oresteia* (458 BCE) supplies the classical form of the question the film answers. Orestes kills his mother to avenge his father; the Erinyes, chthonic female powers who avenge kindred blood, pursue him; at Athens, Athena convenes the first court. Apollo argues that the mother is not the true parent of the child but only the nurse of the seed. The votes are equal, and Athena casts hers for Orestes, explaining that she favors the male, having had no mother. The matricide is acquitted. The Erinyes are then persuaded, with a reminder that Athena alone knows the keys of the chamber where Zeus's thunderbolt is kept, to accept an honored dwelling beneath the city. As the Eumenides they will receive offerings before marriage and childbirth.

Froma Zeitlin's "The Dynamics of Misogyny" (1978) read the trilogy as a founding myth of patriarchal order: the subordination of the female, and the domestication of female rage into a blessing on the institutions that subordinate it. Emily's arc follows the Eumenidean pattern, since a dead woman with a claim of blood becomes the blesser of a marriage. Is this a domestication?

The film differs at the decisive point. In Athens the killer of the woman is acquitted; in *Corpse Bride* the killer of the woman is condemned. Emily becomes a Eumenis only after the Erinys's case has been won, and her blessing is not extracted by persuasion under threat but given as her own act. *Corpse Bride* rewrites the *Oresteia*'s verdict, and with it the myth of origin that feminist classical scholarship found at the foundation of Western law.

8.5 *Justice, vengeance, forgiveness*

Hamlet's father returns from the dead to demand that his son remember and avenge him, and the tragedy that follows consumes the living. Emily demands no vengeance, and justice occurs without her violence.

Arendt's account of action supplies the categories. Vengeance is re-action, automatic and predictable, binding the actors to the original deed in an endless chain. Forgiveness is a new action that releases both the one who forgives and the one forgiven. Human beings, she adds, are unable to forgive what they cannot punish, and unable to punish what has proved unforgivable. The film assigns forgiveness and punishment to their proper objects. Victor's trespass, a careless vow, a deceit, a flight, is forgiven. Barkis's crime is punished. Neither is confused with the other.

Derrida's “Force of Law” (1990) distinguished justice, undeconstructible and infinite, from law, which is calculable and can be deconstructed. *Specters of Marx* (1993) extended the demand for justice to those who are not present, the dead and the not yet born, as the condition of any responsible politics of memory. Benjamin's sixth thesis warned that even the dead will not be safe from the enemy if he wins. In *Corpse Bride* the enemy does not win. The dead secure their own justice, and they secure it without becoming the enemy's image.

The film's moral topology can now be stated. It performs four acts in a fixed order: punishment for the guilty, forgiveness for the trespasser, remission toward the innocent, and a gift toward the other bride. The order matters, because the release of the innocent is conditional on the judgment of the guilty. A remission that preceded justice would be a victim's surrender of her claim to recognition, and a gift given before the wrong was named would be indistinguishable from the self-sacrifice the film refuses. The film's theory of justice is that the victim's generosity is possible, and not complicit, only once her wrong has been seen and judged.

CHAPTER NINE

9 Psyche, Pupa, Imago: Metamorphosis, Music, and the Ontology of the Medium

The film's final image condenses a constellation of words and things, *psychē*, *pupa*, puppet, *imago*, whose convergence shows that the film's medium, its heroine, and its ending form a single figure: the doll that becomes a soul.

9.1 *Psyche*

Greek *psychē* meant breath, life, and soul, and it also named the butterfly. Aristotle's *History of Animals* (V.19) uses the word for the winged creatures that emerge from caterpillars, and late antique funerary art represented the soul leaving the body as a butterfly, or as a girl with butterfly wings. When Emily dissolves into butterflies, the film reaches the oldest image in the Western repertoire for the soul's release.

The myth of Psyche in Apuleius' *Metamorphoses* (Books IV–VI) is the narrative form of that image, and its correspondences with *Corpse Bride* are close. An oracle commands that Psyche be dressed for a funereal marriage and exposed on a crag for a monstrous husband, so that the wedding procession is a funeral. In the hidden palace she must not see her husband; she lights a lamp, a drop of hot oil wakes and wounds him, and he flees. She wanders, undergoes trials, descends to the underworld, and at last is given a cup of ambrosia that makes her immortal, whereupon the marriage is celebrated among the gods. Erich Neumann's *Amor and Psyche* (1952) read the tale as a myth of feminine individuation organized around the marriage of death, in which the maiden's wedding is her death to an earlier self.

Corpse Bride reproduces the funereal wedding, the dangerous light (Victor's candle sets a dress alight at the rehearsal), the descent, and the cup. It inverts the

conclusion. Psyche's cup makes her a wife forever. Emily's refusal of the cup makes her free.

9.2 *Pupa*

The Latin *pupa* meant girl and doll. Eighteenth-century entomology, in the nomenclature associated with Linnaeus, applied the word to the insect's intermediate stage, in which the larval body dissolves inside a case that resembles a swaddled doll. “Puppet” descends, through Old French, from the same word. The stop-motion puppet is a pupa in every sense: a doll, here a girl, inside which a life is staged and from which a new form emerges.

Heinrich von Kleist's “On the Marionette Theatre” (1810) argued that the marionette surpasses the human dancer in grace because it has no self-consciousness to distort its movement: grace appears purest in the body with either no consciousness or an infinite one, in the puppet or in the god. Paradise is bolted behind us, Kleist's interlocutor concludes, and the way back lies forward, through the world and through knowledge. Emily's final act has the grace Kleist describes. It is done without self-display, and it seems, at the last, to pass through knowledge into innocence.

The puppet is also the classic object of the uncanny. Ernst Jentsch (1906) located the uncanny in uncertainty whether a thing is animate; Freud (1919), reading Hoffmann's Olimpia, located it in the return of the familiar repressed. Masahiro Mori's account of the uncanny valley (1970) observed that near-human figures provoke revulsion while stylized ones invite sympathy, and the film's design keeps its puppets on the near side of the valley, so that a dead bride's face can carry grief and generosity without horror. Sergei Eisenstein's notes on Disney praised the plasmaticness of animated form, its freedom from fixed shape. In *Corpse Bride* plasmaticness belongs to the dead, whose bodies come apart and recombine, while the living are rigid. The medium's freedom is assigned to the underworld.

André Bazin's “Ontology of the Photographic Image” (1945) traced the plastic arts to a mummy complex, the impulse to preserve the body against time by embalming, and saw in photography the fulfilment of that impulse. Roland Barthes's *Camera Lucida* (1980) found in every photograph the message “that-has-been,” and in that message the announcement of a death. Laura Mulvey's *Death 24x a Second* (2006) argued that the stillness hidden inside the moving image is cinema's relation to death. Stop-motion makes the hidden stillness the whole substance of the medium. It consists of still photographs of jointed bodies, between which no movement ever occurred, and its motion is produced only in projection, in the gap between exposures. Every movement on screen is a

resurrection. The medium of *Corpse Bride* is itself a corpse bride: still images wedded to motion.

The film reflects on this. Emily's detachable body, with its visible joints and its parts that come away and return, exposes the articulation of the puppet in the person of the heroine. And the animator's hand, which gives motion to the puppet and then withdraws so that the camera may record it, enacts in every frame the ethic the story reaches only in its last scene. The medium is an ethics of remission: life given, and the giver's hand withdrawn.

9.3 *Imago*

Linnaeus named the adult insect the *imago*, the perfected image of its species. In Rome the *imagines* were wax masks of ancestors who had held high office, kept in cupboards in the atrium and worn at funerals by men who resembled the dead in stature and bearing, so that the ancestors seemed to walk again in procession (Polybius VI.53). The right to display them marked nobility. The imago was the instrument by which the dead governed the living: lineage as mortmain.

The ancestral portraits of the Everglot house are *imagines* in this sense, and the butterfly at the film's end is a counter-imago, an image of the dead that releases the living rather than binding them.

Carl Jung took the word *imago*, from Carl Spitteler's novel of 1906, for the unconscious image of a parent or beloved that shapes one's relations to real persons. Victor begins the film with a bridal imago, the bride as a role prescribed by families, and ends it in relation to two real women. Entomology adds a final term. Within the pupa, as the larval body dissolves, clusters of cells, the imaginal discs described by August Weismann in the 1860s, carry the form of the adult. The dissolution contains the plan of what will emerge. The corpse is a chrysalis.

9.4 *Ovid revised*

Ovid's *Metamorphoses* is the West's great catalogue of transformed women, and most of their transformations are escapes from, or sequels to, male sexual violence. Daphne becomes a laurel to escape rape by Apollo, and Syrinx becomes reeds to escape rape by Pan. Jupiter rapes Io and then turns her into a heifer to hide her from Juno. Philomela is raped by her sister's husband, Tereus, who cuts out her tongue to silence her; she weaves an account of the crime for her sister and is later transformed into a bird. Arachne, whose tapestry depicted the gods' rapes of mortal women, is beaten by Minerva, tries to hang herself, and is turned into a spider. Echo is reduced to a voice. Amy Richlin's “Reading Ovid's Rapes” (1992) indicted the aestheticization of violence in these episodes.

Emily's metamorphosis inverts the pattern. It is chosen rather than imposed, it follows justice rather than flight, and it is a departure from a concluded case rather than an escape from a pursuer. It may be the first metamorphosis in this lineage that a woman authors.

Arachne also returns, reconciled. Emily's companions include a black widow spider who, with other spiders, tends and mends her bridal finery. Nancy K. Miller's "Arachnologies" (1986) proposed the web as a figure for women's writing, the signature of the weaver in the text. Penelope wove a shroud by day and unpicked it by night to defer a remarriage; the Moirai spin, measure, and cut the thread of life; Louise Bourgeois's monumental spider *Maman* (1999) made the spider an emblem of the mother as weaver and protector. The dead bride is surrounded by a female artisanal community that prepares her for her second wedding and, as it turns out, for her departure.

9.5 *The musical-erotic*

The piano passes through three bodies. Victor plays at the Everglot house; Victoria, forbidden to play, listens and is drawn to him; Emily, in the Land of the Dead, plays with a virtuosity that exceeds his, and then the two play a duet.

Kierkegaard's *Either/Or* (1843) argued that music is the medium of sensuous immediacy, the art of the musical-erotic, and found its perfection in Mozart's *Don Giovanni*. Schopenhauer held that music is an immediate copy of the will itself, and Nietzsche made it the Dionysian ground from which tragedy is born. The forbidden piano is forbidden because it is the voice of desire, and the film's three pianists are distinguished by their relation to that voice. Victor has it without confidence; Victoria is denied it; Emily possesses it fully.

Jane Campion's *The Piano* (1993) is the closest modern analogue. A mute woman married by her father's arrangement to a colonial landowner speaks only through her piano; when her husband discovers her desire for another man, he cuts off her finger with an axe. Both films place a finger at the junction of music, marriage, and ownership. Renaissance lore, drawing on late antique sources such as Macrobius, held that a vein ran from the ring finger directly to the heart. In Campion the husband severs the finger of a woman's eros; in *Corpse Bride* a finger rises from the earth to claim a husband. The one film shows a woman's desire punished through the body of marriage, the other a woman's desire returning through the token of marriage.

The duet is the film's one true conversation. Cavell's remarriage couples are defined by conversation between equals, and the duet has its structure: call and response, rivalry and cooperation, the pleasure of matched skill. It is the moment Victor and Emily become friends, and it is the condition of what follows, since

remission is possible only between equals. It is neither the concession of a superior nor the surrender of an inferior. Ernst Bloch called music the most utopian of the arts, the anticipation of a not-yet, and the duet anticipates the ending: a relation in which neither party owns the other.

9.6 *Becoming-imperceptible*

Deleuze and Guattari's A *Thousand Plateaus* (1980) describes becoming-animal as a passage into packs, swarms, and multiplicities, and holds that every becoming passes through becoming-woman and tends toward becoming-imperceptible. Emily's exit follows this line exactly. She leaves the couple, a fixed and bounded form, becomes a swarm, a multiplicity without a center, and disappears into the moonlight. The conjugal dyad, the molar unit of the marriage plot, is exited along a line of flight.

Rosi Braidotti's *Metamorphoses* (2002) builds a feminist materialism of becoming from such passages, and Bataille describes eroticism as the dissolution of the discontinuous being into continuity. Emily's dissolution is Bataillean without violence and Zhuangzian without irony, and it remains suspended, as Chapter 3 showed, between Lucretian dispersal and Platonic ascent.

The moon completes the figure. Hélène Cixous's "Sorties" (1975) listed the hierarchical oppositions of Western thought, activity and passivity, sun and moon, culture and nature, day and night, and showed that the feminine is always assigned the second term. The film assigns Emily the moon and revalues it. The cold, fruitless moon to which Theseus would have sent a disobedient daughter becomes the horizon of a freed woman. Artemis, virgin goddess of the moon, stood outside the market of marriage. Emily rises to her sky not because she was denied a marriage but because she has given one away.



PART THREE

Synthesis

10 · Imaginal Humanism

CHAPTER TEN

Imaginal Humanism: Toward a Theory of Remission

The readings converge on a single thesis. *Corpse Bride* proposes a humanism in which the human is constituted not by what it possesses and can enforce but by what it can undergo and release, and whose paradigmatic act is the remission of a valid claim by one who has secured her justice and her voice. This chapter states the thesis in four propositions, distinguishes remission from sacrifice, restores the film's buried source, answers the principal objections, and draws out the implications.

10.1 *From mortmain to psyche*

The film's arc can be told as a history of hands. It begins with the figurative dead hand of lineage and capital, the mortmain under which two families dispose of their children. It raises a literal dead hand from the forest floor, which receives a ring and acquires a claim: the hand becomes *manus*, the power of a spouse over a spouse, enforced by recapture. It ends with that hand opening, the ring returned to the living and the man released by an act of the dead woman's will, *manumissio testamento*. Finally it converts the hand into a soul: the woman whose dead hand began the story leaves it as *psychē*, a cloud of butterflies. From mortmain to psyche is the shape of the film and of the argument.

10.2 *First proposition: the chiasmus*

In the human world, life and death are juridical and symbolic distributions before they are biological facts. Societies decide who has a will, whose voice counts, whose loss is grievable, and whose capabilities are developed or suppressed. The Seneca Falls Declaration's "civilly dead," Butler's grievability, Nussbaum's capabilities, and the film's chromatic inversion converge on one criterion: a humanism must measure persons by the distribution of will, voice, grievability, and capability, not by biological life alone. The criterion is not a sentimental exaltation of the dead. It is an analytic that exposes the forms of death the living impose on the living.

The law itself already acknowledges that juridical personhood can outlast biological life. Article 171 of the French Civil Code, amended at the end of 1959 after the Malpasset dam disaster, allows the President of the Republic, for serious reasons, to authorize a marriage when one of the intended spouses has died, provided the facts establish that person's consent beyond doubt. Evans-Pritchard documented Nuer ghost marriage, in which a woman is married in the name of a dead man and her children are counted as his. In parts of rural China, ghost marriage (*minghun*) still pairs a son who died unmarried with a woman's body so that he will not be alone in the afterlife, and the demand has created a trade in women's corpses. Men have been jailed for digging up women's bodies and selling them to bereaved families (PRI, 2013), and men have been convicted of, or charged with, murdering women in order to sell their bodies as ghost brides; one was executed in 2013 (AFP via TimesLIVE, 2013; Sixth Tone, 2016). The traffic in women analyzed in Chapter 7 does not stop at death, and at its extreme it manufactures corpse brides by killing. The film's fantasy of marriage across death has institutional counterparts, and criminal ones. What none of these institutions contains is a doctrine of release.

10.3 *Second proposition: remission*

The remissive performative can now be defined fully. It is an utterance or act by which the holder of a valid claim against another extinguishes it, gratuitously and freely, in a form addressed to and received by the party released. Its felicity conditions are five:

1. **Standing.** The remitter holds a valid claim. A remission by one who holds none is a misfire, a mere renunciation.
2. **Freedom.** The act is uncoerced. A remission extracted by threat is an abuse: extortion wearing the form of a gift.
3. **Knowledge.** The remitter knows what she releases and to whom.

4. **Gratuity.** No counter-performance is demanded or expected.
5. **Uptake.** The release is addressed to its beneficiary and received in a public form.

Arendt identified two faculties that redeem human action from its predicaments: the promise, which binds an unpredictable future, and forgiveness, which releases an irreversible past. Remission is a third. It releases neither a future nor a past but a right, a present claim upon another's future. It cannot be reduced to forgiveness, which addresses a wrong, nor to non-enforcement, which is an omission rather than an act.

Its political form is paradoxical: it is the act by which a sovereign subject uses its sovereignty to undo its own hold. Each framework reviewed in earlier chapters can be located in relation to it. Kant's right to a person akin to a right over things is the right remission renounces. Hegel's ethical marriage is exceeded, since the union Emily founds is one she does not enter. Pateman's sexual contract is exited not by breach but by gift. Mill's statement of 1851 is a historical prototype, the remission by an empowered husband of powers the law gave him. The common-law release by deed is its juridical analogue, and the ring, a signet in an older usage, its seal.

Simone Weil's notion of decreation (*Gravity and Grace*, 1947), the consent to withdraw oneself so that another may be, is its mystical cognate. Remission nonetheless differs from decreation in a way that matters for feminist ethics. Decreation is a spiritual self-undoing before God, and Weil's own death shows how near it can come to self-destruction. She died in 1943, at thirty-four, in a sanatorium in Kent, having refused to eat more than the rations available in occupied France; the coroner recorded that she had killed herself by refusing food while the balance of her mind was disturbed, a verdict her biographers have contested. Remission is a juridical and ethical act toward particular persons, performed by someone who has first secured her own standing.

10.4 *Third proposition: the sororal transaction*

The universal of humanism passes, in this film, through a particular relation between two women. That is not an accident of plot but a correction of theory. Irigaray argued that the universal subject of the Western tradition is a masculine particular; Cavarero argued that ethics begins not with an abstract Man but with a unique “who” whose story another tells. Levinas's face, on this account, is not a faceless alterity but a face with a story, and Emily stops because she knows Victoria's story, which was once her own.

Gift theory explains the form of the ending. Marcel Mauss's *Essay on the Gift* (1925) showed that the archaic gift imposes three obligations, to give, to receive,

and to reciprocate, so that every gift founds a debt. Derrida's *Given Time* (1991) drew the aporia: a gift recognized as a gift and returned as gratitude has already become exchange, so a pure gift must not appear as such to giver or receiver, and its condition is a kind of forgetting. Lewis Hyde's *The Gift* (1983) added that a gift stays alive only by moving on, away from the giver.

Emily's dissolution is the logical form of a gift that founds no debt. A giver who remained would be owed gratitude forever, and the living couple would live under a new mortmain, the claim of a benefactor. By disappearing, the giver makes the gift unrepayable and therefore free. The bouquet, thrown to the next bride, moves the gift onward, as Hyde says it must. What looks like sentiment is the solution to a problem in the logic of giving.

10.5 *Fourth proposition: imaginal metamorphosis*

Pico della Mirandola grounded human dignity in the capacity for self-transformation. Ovid showed what transformation had meant for women: something done to them, in flight from violence or as its sequel. The correction the film proposes is that the dignity of transformation belongs to its author. Emily's metamorphosis is authored, and it is the climax of her dignity, not its loss.

The ending also unites the two great twentieth-century philosophies of finitude. Heidegger made mortality the horizon of authentic existence; Arendt answered with natality, the capacity to begin. The film fuses them in a single image. A dead woman's last act is a beginning, both of the living couple's chosen union and of her own new form. The corpse is a chrysalis.

Henry Corbin's essay “Mundus Imaginalis” (1964) distinguished the imaginary, the unreal product of fantasy, from the imaginal: an intermediate world, described by Suhrawardī and Ibn ʿArabī, between the sensible and the intelligible, in which spiritual realities take on bodies and bodies become spiritual. The Land of the Dead is imaginal in Corbin's sense. It is not a fantasy but a world where ethical realities take bodily form, so that grief can sing, a claim can rise from the ground, and a release can be seen as flight. Its stop-motion figures are, in Corbin's vocabulary, subtle bodies.

“Imaginal” also names the cells within the pupa that carry the adult form through the dissolution of the larva. *Imaginal humanism* therefore names three things at once. It is a humanism of the intermediate world, which grasps the human through images that release rather than bind. It is a humanism of metamorphosis, which measures a person by the forms she can author. And it is a humanism of the cells of a future form carried through dissolution, which refuses to treat death, loss, or relinquishment as simple negation.

10.6 *Remission and sacrifice*

The most serious objection from feminist criticism must be met directly. Is Emily's departure not one more instance of a woman effacing herself so that a couple may form? The traditions the film inherits are full of such women, and feminist criticism has rightly indicted them. The distinction between remission and sacrifice can be drawn by five criteria. *Standing* asks whether the departing woman holds a valid claim. *Freedom* asks whether her departure is uncoerced. *Judgment* asks whether the wrong done to her is acknowledged and judged. *Generativity* asks whether her act founds a new relation rather than restoring an old order. *Luminosity* asks whether her departure is a public image rather than an erasure.

Figure (source)	Mode of departure	Valid claim	Uncoerced	Wrong judged	New relation founded	Image, not erasure
Alcestis (Euripides, 438 BCE)	Dies in her husband's place	No: she pays his debt	Formally	No wrong is tried	No: the old marriage is restored	No: returns veiled and silent
Bertha Mason (*Jane Eyre*, 1847)	Dies in a fire she sets	Yes, as lawful wife	No: confined as mad	No	No: clears the way for another marriage	No: erased
Miss Havisham (*Great Expectations*, 1861)	Arrested at the jilting; dies of burns	Yes, against her betrayer	Self-imposed	Only in another plot	No: vengeance by proxy	No
Clarissa (Richardson, 1748)	Authors her own death	Yes	Yes	Yes, belatedly	No: withdrawal	Yes: her coffin and letters
Giselle (1841)	Shields her betrayer; returns to the grave	Yes	Yes	No: the guilty man is spared	No: the noble match resumes	Partly: vanishes at dawn
Cio-Cio-San (*Madama Butterfly*, 1904)	Yields her child; suicide	Yes, as she understood it	No: abandonment and shame	No	Only under compulsion	No: death as spectacle
Stella Dallas (Vidor, 1937; Cavell)	Watches her daughter's wedding; walks away	Yes, as mother	Yes	No: class contempt unjudged	Yes: the daughter's marriage	Yes: the walk toward the camera
The Erinyes (Aeschylus, *Eumenides*, 458 BCE)	Become guardians beneath Athens	Yes, for blood-guilt	No: persuaded under threat	No: the killer is acquitted	Yes: they bless marriages	Yes: honored in procession
Emily (*Corpse Bride*, 2005)	Returns the ring; becomes butterflies	Yes	Yes	Yes: the murderer is condemned	Yes: the living couple's union	Yes: the ascent in moonlight

Only Emily meets all five criteria. Clarissa and Stella Dallas come closest, each meeting four. Clarissa authors her death and is vindicated, but founds no new

relation; her triumph is withdrawal. Cavell reads Stella's final walk, away from her daughter's wedding and toward the camera, as the assertion of an existence that no longer depends on the recognition of others, but the class contempt that drove her out is never judged. The Eumenides meet generativity and luminosity but fail freedom and judgment, which is the substance of Zeitlin's critique. Giselle is free and generous, but her betrayer is spared and the order he serves resumes.

The comparison with *Madama Butterfly* is the most instructive, because the film cites it so closely. Both heroines wait for a man who betrayed them; both confront a second bride; both yield; both are associated with the butterfly. But Cio-Cio-San yields under abandonment and shame and dies by her own hand, the paradigm of what Clément called the undoing of women, while Emily yields after justice, by her own will, into transformation. The film cites the butterfly bride of opera in order to correct her.

10.7 *Restitution: the Lurianic frame*

The tale the film adapted belongs to a Jewish narrative world whose speculative summit is the Kabbalah of Isaac Luria in sixteenth-century Safed, as reconstructed by Gershom Scholem in *Major Trends in Jewish Mysticism* (1941). Three Lurianic doctrines bear on the film. *Tzimtzum* is God's self-contraction, a withdrawal that makes room for a world that is not God. *Shevirat ha-kelim*, the breaking of the vessels, describes the shattering of vessels unable to contain the divine light, which scatters sparks into the material world. *Tikkun* is the repair of the world, accomplished in part through human acts that raise the scattered sparks.

The homology is structural. Emily's murder is a breaking of the vessel; her bound existence among the dead is the exile of a spark; her remission is a *tzimtzum*, a withdrawal that makes room for the existence of others; and the luminous swarm that rises from the church is an image of sparks raised. The claim is not that the filmmakers intended Lurianic theology. It is that the tale's logic survived its de-Judaization, and that reading it back into its tradition is an act of restitution. Derrida's hauntology would call it justice toward a specter: the acknowledgment of what an inheritance buried.

The thesis thereby performs, upon the film's own erasure, the act the film performs for its bride. It returns what was buried to its due, and then lets it go.

10.8 *Objections and replies*

The vanishing woman. The film still requires the passionate dead woman to disappear so that a living, propertied couple may marry, which is Bertha Mason's fate in a kinder key. Lee Edelman's *No Future* (2004) would add that the film sacrifices the figure of the death drive to reproductive futurism, the politics organized around the future and its children. The objection is partly conceded. The film cannot imagine Emily's survival in the living world because that world remains civilly deadly, so her departure indicts the world, not the woman. The future she secures is not the reproductive future of a child but the freedom of two adults to choose each other, and it is given rather than imposed. But the critique stands to this extent: the film locates female freedom beyond the world it criticizes.

The restoration of marriage. The institution under critique is reinstated at the end. The reply is that it is reinstated in Cavell's sense, as remarriage, a union founded on conversation and choice rather than contract. The film is reformist, not abolitionist. Victor's failure at the rehearsal, read with Halberstam, and the cross-ontological marriage, read with Butler's account of kinship trouble, mark points where the film's critique exceeds its resolution.

The erasure of the source. This objection is addressed by restitution but not dissolved. The de-Judaization remains a fact about the film, and the restitution is an act of criticism, not of the film.

The racialized carnival. The vitality of the dead is coded through Black musical idiom borrowed from Calloway, by way of the Fleischer cartoons, and performed by a white voice in an all-white world. No reply dissolves this objection. The humanism the film proposes is limited by the whiteness of its imagined world, and an imaginal humanism adequate to its own claims would have to acknowledge whose music gives the dead their life.

Class. The film satirizes merchant and aristocrat alike but leaves servants as comic ciphers. The coachman who dies and returns as a messenger shares the surname of Henry Mayhew, whose *London Labour and the London Poor* (1851) recorded the lives the Victorian novel rarely saw. Whether or not the echo is intended, the film's chiasmus is drawn within the propertied classes. The objection is conceded.

Spectacle. The ending offers the vanishing woman as a sight for a watching couple, in the manner Mulvey analyzed. The reply is that the spectacle is of a choice rather than a death, and that its spectators are recipients of a gift rather than consumers of an image. The objection is partly conceded: the film knows the risk and does not wholly escape it.

10.9 *Implications*

For feminist ethics, imaginal humanism offers a third term in the debate Carol Gilligan's *In a Different Voice* (1982) opened between an ethic of care and an ethic of justice. Remission neither maintains a relationship, as care does, nor enforces a right, as justice does. It releases a right in order to found a relation one does not enter. It is available only to those who hold rights, which is why the history of women's exclusion from rights is also the history of their exclusion from this form of moral agency.

For the philosophy of law, the film poses a question the law has avoided. Dead-hand control persists in trusts, in testamentary conditions restraining marriage, in posthumous reproduction, and in the long afterlife of settlements. The rule against perpetuities is the law's compelled remission of the dead hand, imposed from outside after a fixed period. The film imagines a voluntary remission granted from within, and asks whether the claims of the dead might be released by the dead, or on their behalf, and on what conditions.

For death studies, the film distinguishes two kinds of bond with the dead that grief theory often conflates. The reunions of the anabasis affirm bonds of memory, which the continuing-bonds model rightly defends. The vow binds by obligation, and healthy grief releases it. The film's formula is continuing bonds without claims.

For the theory of animation, the film shows that stop-motion is a philosophical medium whose ontology, still frames, a withdrawing hand, a doll that becomes a figure, enacts the ethic it depicts. Animation is the art of giving life and letting go, and *Corpse Bride* is the film in which that art becomes its own subject.

CONCLUSION

The Ring and the Moon



Corpse Bride begins with a man releasing a butterfly from beneath a glass and ends with a woman releasing a man from a vow and becoming butterflies. Between those two releases it constructs a complete philosophy of obligation and its remission, and that philosophy grounds a humanism of release.

The genealogy reconstructed in Part One showed that the film's tale type is ancient and widely distributed: the Ashkenazi tale of the betrothed finger, the ring given to Venus, the revenant brides of Phlegon and Goethe, the troth returned in the ballads, the Wilis of *Giselle*. Across all of them the power to release the living from a bond with the dead lay outside the claimant. The film's decisive alteration was to transfer that power to the claimant herself. Its five principal authors had independently been working toward the same problem, and its ethic of remission is overdetermined by its collective authorship.

The readings of Part Two traced the consequences. Under coverture the living bride was civilly dead, and the chromatic inversion of the film's two worlds is the visible form of that juridical fact: the dead bride is the only woman in the film who possesses a will. The vow that drives the plot is Austin's paradigm performative; the film takes Derrida's side against Austin's exclusion of the citational, then goes beyond both by naming an exit from a vow that neither fulfills, annuls, breaches, nor repudiates it. The Land of the Dead is a commonwealth and an archive of the ungrieved, whose carnival exceeds its license because it produces a juridical event, and whose vitality is borrowed, problematically, from a culture the film does not represent. The two brides transact a man between themselves as a gift, through the one rite of the wedding that passes from woman to woman. The pharmakon prepared for a love-death kills the guilty, and the film's theory of justice makes the victim's generosity conditional on the judgment of her wrong. The final image condenses psyche, pupa, and imago into a figure of the medium itself: the doll that becomes a soul.

Part Three stated the synthesis as imaginal humanism, in four propositions: that life and death are juridical and symbolic distributions before they are biological facts; that the remissive performative is a third faculty of action beside promise and forgiveness; that the universal of humanism passes through particular relations, here between women; and that the dignity of transformation belongs to its author. It distinguished remission from sacrifice by five criteria and showed that, among the departing women of the Western tradition, only the corpse bride meets them all. It restored, through the Lurianic doctrines of contraction, breaking, and repair, the frame the adaptation buried. And it conceded what must be conceded: that the film locates female freedom beyond the world it criticizes, restores the institution it questions, effaces its source, borrows its vitality, confines its chiasmus to the propertied classes, and does not wholly escape the spectacle of the vanishing woman.

The implications reach beyond the film. Feminist ethics gains a term beyond the opposition of care and justice. The philosophy of law gains a question about the voluntary release of the dead hand. Death studies gains a distinction between bonds of memory and bonds of obligation. The theory of animation gains an example of a medium whose ontology is its ethics.

The film's last images can now be read in full. A ring passes from a dead hand into a living one, not as a claim but as a release. A bouquet passes from a dead bride to a living one, not as a rival's surrender but as a gift that keeps moving. And a woman who rose from the earth at the beginning of the story rises past the moon at its end, not because she was denied a place among the living but because she has made one for others. The oldest figure of power over persons, the hand, has learned the gesture the animator's hand performs in every frame of the film: to give life, and to let go.

A humanism adequate to the living and the dead alike would measure a person not by what she can hold but by what she can release without ceasing to be herself. That is the measure *Corpse Bride* proposes, and by it the corpse bride is the most fully human figure in the film.

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Keywords



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